

Quiet Hours 3rd Draft
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EXT. CITY ROOFTOP - NIGHT

Wind howls around BENJAMIN PRICE (20, tall, heavy-set, curly dark hair, piercing blue eyes). He looks wrecked, like he has been crying for hours.

Humidity clings to his skin. Sirens wail faintly below. A spotlight from a police cruiser cuts through the dark.

He stands at the ledge, trembling. Dried tears. Tight chest. Voices behind him, urgent but unreal.

Heat rises off the streets below. The shouting behind him is barely there, like it is coming through water.

POLICE OFFICER (O.S.)
(through megaphone)
We can talk, Benjamin. Just step back.

A hand clamps his arm. He whips around and locks eyes with the OFFICER.

BENJAMIN
Let go of me.

OFFICER
Let me help you.

The officer's voice stays calm, trained.

BENJAMIN
You can't help me. I don't want help. You don't get to pull me back.

He jerks his arm free.

The shift in weight is instant. His heel slips.

The city drops away.

The officer lunges.

Benjamin's eyes widen. Then blackness swallows him.

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - UNKNOWN TIME

Benjamin's eyes snap open. He gasps, chokes, coughs hard. Grit and panic claw at his throat.

BENJAMIN
Oh. What the fuck?

White ceiling. Buzzing silence. A sterile, windowless room with one wooden bed. Gray clothes folded neatly. No monitors. No machines.

He tries to sit. Winces. Then groans.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
Great. I can't even do that right.
Should've picked a higher
building.

He staggers to the door and rattles the knob. Locked.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
Hello?

Nothing. Movement across the hall. A girl's wide, blinking eyes. Then a second figure behind her, smiling like they know him.

A jingle. Keys.

The door opens. DR. ANNA (30s) enters, luminous and calm, unsettlingly still. An ORDERLY looms behind her.

ANNA
Hi, Ben. I'm Anna. I've been
waiting to talk to you.

BENJAMIN
Benjamin.

ANNA
My mistake. Do you know where you
are?

BENJAMIN
No. All I remember is falling,
then I woke up here.

ANNA
That must have been terrifying.
I'll be back soon.

She exits. The orderly shuts the door. Click. Then, after a beat, it swings open on its own.

A beat. BENJAMIN steps into the hallway, barefoot.

INT. WARD HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Dim green light. Pale floors. Identical rooms, repeating like a set.

He passes a wall of clocks, none ticking. One runs backward.

He squints -- one clock runs backward.

REGAN (O.S.)
Hey, there he is!

REGAN (20s), curly-haired and bright, skips toward him. Mismatched socks. A friendly smile that does not quite reach her eyes.

REGAN (CONT'D)
I was wondering when you would wake up. I'm Regan.

BENJAMIN
I'm Benjamin. Where am I?

REGAN
They didn't tell you? Ugh. They never do.

She lowers her voice.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Mental facility. Sort of. Kind of. It's weird here.

BENJAMIN
I'm picking up on that.

REGAN
(laughs, then softens)
What happened to you?

BENJAMIN
Life got hard. I wanted out. And somebody stopped me.

REGAN
Don't say that. Depression lies. Trust me, I know.

She gently taps her stomach.

Benjamin looks confused.

REGAN (CONT'D)
I just wanted to be thin. Took too many pills. Not to die. Just to speed things up.

A beat.

REGAN (CONT'D)
But hey, we're here. So I guess we get another chance?

She flashes a crooked smile. He almost smiles back, then stops himself.

BENJAMIN
Do they let people out of here?

REGAN
Sort of. People disappear. After that, nobody can remember their names. It's like they never existed.

BENJAMIN
That's not comforting.

REGAN
Come on. I'll show you around.

She reaches for his hand. He hesitates, then takes it. As they walk down the hallway.

A SHADOW passes at the end. Just for a second. Too tall. Too slow. Then gone.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. CAFETERIA - LATER

A cold, gray cafeteria. Plastic trays. Flickering fluorescent lights.

BENJAMIN sits alone, toying with a bruised apple.

A man in a tattered military coat drops onto the bench beside him.

OTTO
You're in my spot.

BENJAMIN
 Sorry. Didn't know there were
 rules about seats.

OTTO
 There aren't. But that one's mine.

BENJAMIN
 Right. My bad. I'm Benjamin.

OTTO
 Otto. Private First Class. Forty-
 second Infantry.
 (leans in)
 You smell like concrete dust and
 guilt. That's how you know you're
 fresh.

Benjamin gives a faint, uncertain chuckle.

BENJAMIN
 You always talk like that?

OTTO
 Only when I'm awake.

He scans the walls suspiciously.

OTTO (CONT'D)
 Don't trust the mirrors. They send
 signals. She watches.

BENJAMIN
 She who?

A voice chimes in from a few seats down.

CARMILLA (O.S.)
 Otto, stop scaring the boy. He
 hasn't even been here 24 hours.

CARMILLA (60s), regal and out of place in a high-necked
 blouse from another century, sips herbal tea from a chipped
 porcelain cup.

CARMILLA (TO BENJAMIN) (CONT'D)
 If you pray, pray hard. If you
 don't, now's a fine time to learn.

BENJAMIN
 Okay. This place just keeps
 getting better.

From behind them, a sudden BANG! A door slams.

Everyone flinches.

JACE (30s) stands in the doorway. Hoodie, boots, scars, attitude to spare.

He stares down the room like he owns it. Or wants to burn it down.

He strides past everyone. Tosses a roll onto his tray. Doesn't sit.

REGAN (O.S.)
That's Jace. Don't bother.

BENJAMIN
Is he always like that?

REGAN
Crazy? Dangerous? Probably. Mostly just done. Wants out. He's angry all the time. Not even sure what he did to get stuck here.

INT. DOCTOR'S OFFICE - LATER

Dim. Candlelit. Like a séance, not a session.

DR. ANNA sits cross-legged, hands folded.

DR. ANNA
Hello, Benjamin.

BENJAMIN
Why can't I call my sister?

DR. ANNA
I want to help you. First, what do you remember?

BENJAMIN
I remember the fall. Then here. That's it.

DR. ANNA
So, you jumped?

BENJAMIN
Answer my question first. And how do you not know that?

She smiles. Not unkind. Not comforting either.

DR. ANNA
I'm so sorry. I have to go. We'll
talk again.

She leaves before he can speak.

INT. HALLWAY - NIGHT

Regan hums, off-key and aimless, outside Benjamin's room.

BENJAMIN
What are you doing?

REGAN
Humming keeps the voices out.

BENJAMIN
What voices?

REGAN
The ones in the walls. You'll hear
them soon enough.
(pauses)
I like your eyes, by the way.

BENJAMIN looks away nervously.

BENJAMIN
Thanks. Maybe my one good feature.

REGAN
Don't say that. You've got more
going on than you think. Your eyes
are just loud.
(pause)
Such a bright soul.

INT. GROUP ROOM - NEXT DAY

A therapy circle: DR. ANNA, BENJAMIN, REGAN, CARMILLA,
OTTO, AMBER (20s), pale, in fuzzy socks, clutching a
stuffed cat.

DOCTOR
Why are we all here?

CARMILLA
To atone.

REGAN
To leave.

OTTO
To survive.

AMBER
To find my cat. He's astral
projecting. I'm following him.

BENJAMIN
To talk to my sister. To make
something right.

DOCTOR
Would you take it back? The thing
that brought you here?

A moment.

BENJAMIN
Yes. I think I would.

AMBER
Too late, honey.

The door creaks open. JACE steps in. Leans against the
wall. Doesn't sit.

DOCTOR
Jace. Thank you for joining us.

JACE
Don't flatter yourself. I'm just
here for the drama.

DOCTOR
Would you like to speak?

JACE
Not unless you want to talk about
the black mold in the East Wing or
the deadbolt someone added to the
inside of the kitchen freezer.

Silence.

CARMILLA
(softly)
He's not wrong.

BENJAMIN
How long have you been here?

JACE
Long enough to know this ain't
about healing.

AMBER
(shrugs)
None of it is. We're all waiting
for something. We just don't know
what.

REGAN
Maybe it's not what. Maybe it's
who.

A few of them glance at Regan. No one argues.
A beat.

Jace meets Benjamin's eyes.

JACE
You're not gonna last here if you
trust her.

BENJAMIN
Who? The doctor?

JACE
Her. The walls. The mirrors. Any
of it.

Jace turns and walks out.

The group begins to disperse.

BENJAMIN lingers, eyes darting between Regan and the door
Jace exited through.

CARMILLA mutters a prayer in Latin.

OTTO begins pacing in military formation.

AMBER stays seated. She gently adjusts her plush cat's
ears.

CONT'D -- INT. AMBER'S ROOM - NIGHT
Amber's room is cluttered, cozy,
childlike. Paper stars hang from
the ceiling. A lava lamp glows.
Crayon drawings cover the walls,
all variations of a cat with
glowing eyes.

She places her stuffed cat on the pillow.

AMBER
He saw something. He just won't
say.

She digs through a drawer and pulls out a small metal music box. Winds it, but doesn't open it.

AMBER (CONT'D)
Maybe it's better if we pretend
too. Just for one more night.

She climbs into bed. The lights flicker.

CLICK.

The door she just locked
UNLATCHES.

AMBER (CONT'D)
(sits up)
No, thank you. Not tonight.

Nothing. Silence.

She reaches for the music box, opens it slowly.

A tinny, eerie lullaby plays. The notes begin to reverse.
Slow. Uneven.

Her walls begin to breathe, subtle at first, like the room
itself is sighing.

AMBER (CONT'D)
No. You're early.

She grabs the stuffed cat. Hugs it tight.

A whisper rides the air, so faint it almost isn't there.

WHISPER (V.O.)
He opened the wrong door.

Amber trembles.

She looks to the window. It's fogged from the inside. A
childlike hand print appears on the glass.

AMBER (SOFTLY)
Then we have less time than I
thought.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. DARK ROOM - NIGHT

Benjamin slips through a rusted utility door.

He's in a narrow corridor now. Tile gives way to concrete. Lights buzz and flicker. A heavy metal door creaks open.

INT. UNKNOWN ROOM - CONTINUOUS

A strange room, dimly lit by a single, swaying bulb. It's colder here.

BENJAMIN
(softly)
This isn't on the map.

He steps inside.

The air feels thick, pressing against his skin. He wipes his arm. Damp.

A circular chalky pattern is drawn across the floor. Faded symbols. Burn marks spiderweb out from the center.

Melted candles. Torn fabric. Scratched letters in the tile:

S-H-E-W-A-I-T-S.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
(reads)
"She waits." Who waits?

REGAN (O.S.)
You weren't supposed to see this yet.

Benjamin spins, startled. Regan leans against the door frame, arms folded.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Though, I should've guessed you'd wander. You've got that look.

BENJAMIN
What look?

REGAN
The kind that doesn't sit still when things feel wrong. The kind that breaks stuff to see what's inside.

She walks toward the symbol, barefoot. Calm. Like it doesn't scare her anymore.

BENJAMIN
What is this?

REGAN
A game. A connection. Maybe both.
Or maybe it's nothing. Just our
minds playing telephone with
ghosts.

BENJAMIN
Who are you trying to talk to?

REGAN
I don't really care, I just try to
see if something talks back.

She kneels and traces the edges of the circle with her
finger.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Some say it answers yes or no
questions. Others say it just
listens. Otto says it rewinds
time, but only for the wrong
people. I have no idea what he's
talking about half the time.

BENJAMIN
You believe that?

REGAN
I believe this place is a wound
that won't heal.

Beat.

REGAN (CONT'D)
This whole place is infected.

BENJAMIN
Why hasn't anyone shut it down?
Health inspectors need to come in
here.

REGAN
Because some of us keep playing.
Even when we know better. Someone
is funding this. I guess.

The temperature drops. Benjamin's breath fogs. A low hum
begins, deep and vibrating.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Do you feel that?

BENJAMIN
Yeah. Pressure. Cold.

REGAN
I feel watched.

She looks up at him.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Feels like someone is always
watching.

INT. GROUP ROOM - NEXT DAY

The circle is smaller today. Otto twitches. Carmilla stares at her hands. Amber hums to her stuffed cat. Jace sits near the wall, silent.

DR. ANNA
What did you do last night,
Benjamin?

BENJAMIN
Found a room. There were symbols.

DR. ANNA
And how did it feel?

BENJAMIN
Like I was watching someone else's
dream.
(snaps)
Are you drugging us? Why can't I
think straight?

AMBER
You're not the first to say that.

BENJAMIN
How long has this been going on?
What is this place?

CARMILLA
Not what. When.

OTTO
(cutting in)
You're not asking the right
questions. This isn't therapy.
It's containment.

DR. ANNA
(smiles gently)
I think we're all a little tired.
We'll pick this up tomorrow.

She scribbles something on her notepad, stands.

DR. ANNA (CONT'D)
Be kind to each other. Goodbye.

She leaves too quickly. The air feels like it's holding its breath.

JACE
(from the back)
They always bail when it gets real.

BENJAMIN
I'm done playing nice. I want answers.

JACE
Then stop asking questions like a patient.

INT. BENJAMIN'S ROOM - NIGHT

Benjamin sits cross-legged on the floor. Crumpled papers surround him.

Drawings of the symbols, the circle, the S-H-E-W-A-I-T-S inscription.

Diagrams, arrows, scribbled timelines. He's trying to map the madness.

His hands shake.

BENJAMIN (TO HIMSELF)
This isn't just therapy.

He draws a jagged line through the page, crossing out the lie.

EXTENSION -- INT. BENJAMIN'S ROOM - NIGHT
Papers now blanket the bed, the floor, the desk. Symbols loop and overlap. Notes become paranoid fragments:

(cid:0) "Too clean."

(cid:0) "Mirrors?"

(cid:0) "Not healing. Holding."

(cid:0) "Ask the girl?"

(cid:0) "Who is she and what is she waiting for?"

He stares at the crude sketch of Dr. Anna's face. Her smile too perfect. Her eyes too distant.

A KNOCK.

The door opens with a gentle click.

DR. ANNA
Hello, Benjamin.

She steps inside. No clipboard. No folder.

BENJAMIN
I didn't ask for a session.

DR. ANNA
I know. I felt invited.

She says it like she heard it whispered.

She sits, cross-legged, on the floor across from him.

DR. ANNA (CONT'D)
Do you believe in messages from
the beyond?

BENJAMIN
I believe something's wrong with
this place.

DR. ANNA
Would you like to talk to someone?

BENJAMIN
Talk to who? Isn't that what
you're here for?

DR. ANNA
That depends on the question. I
can't answer your questions. I
wasn't there.

She places her hand gently on the floor between them. Like she's waiting for something.

Benjamin hesitates.

BENJAMIN
What do you want from me?

A long silence. Then, softly,

DR. ANNA
I just wanted to check on you.

She stands.

DR. ANNA (CONT'D)
We'll talk again. When you're ready. Goodbye.

She exits, leaving the candle flickering.

INT. UNUSED HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER

Benjamin wanders the dim corridor outside his room. Walls feel like they're pulsing. Distant whispers hum beneath the fluorescents.

He turns a corner, nearly crashes into JACE, who leans against a door frame, smoking something unlit.

JACE
You ever hear of personal space?

BENJAMIN
Are you following me?

JACE
No. You're finally walking in the right direction.

Benjamin looks at him. Tired. Paranoid. More alert than before.

BENJAMIN
What is she?

JACE
Depends on whose asking.
(pauses)
If you mean the doctor, she's a puppet. Or a radio. Or something worse.

BENJAMIN
She said she was invited.

JACE
So were we. Doesn't mean we RSVP'd.

He opens the door beside him. A dark, dusty storage room with tallies scratched deep into the walls.

JACE (CONT'D)
I've been counting the days. But I think time here loops.

JACE (CONT'D)
Some of these marks were already
here before I made them.

Benjamin looks down. One tally is different. Burned in, not
scratched.

BENJAMIN
You ever try to leave?

JACE
Yeah. Once. Woke up right back in
my bed. Except my bed wasn't in my
room anymore.

A beat.

JACE (CONT'D)
Stick with Regan. Watch Amber.
Avoid mirrors. And don't trust the
doctor. She's not very good at her
job.

He walks away.

Benjamin stays. One hand on the burned tally.

Then a whisper.

WHISPER (V.O.)
Hello?

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. REGAN'S ROOM - DAY

Soft daylight glows through slatted blinds. This room,
unlike any other in the ward, feels human.

Hand-drawn sketches cover the walls, some hopeful, some
frantic. A line of paper cranes hangs like prayer flags. A
small plant, barely alive, clings to a plastic cup on the
windowsill.

A hand-lettered sign above the bed reads: "Hope lives
here."

BENJAMIN and REGAN sit side-by-side on the narrow bed. Legs
almost touching. Silent, for once.

BENJAMIN
You made all this?

REGAN
Keeps me sane. I used to draw
before things stopped being
manageable.

BENJAMIN
What happened?

She doesn't answer immediately. Instead, she pulls at a loose thread in the blanket.

REGAN
I thought if I kept people
laughing, they wouldn't see how
broken I was. Pretending gets
heavy. Eventually, it cracked
something open.

She taps her temple. Then picks up a paper crane, turning it delicately in her fingers.

REGAN (CONT'D)
They said it was a suicide
attempt. I said it was an
accident.
(pause)
Maybe it was both.

BENJAMIN
I get that.

They sit in silence, but it's not awkward.

REGAN
Sometimes I wonder if anyone's
really coming for us. Family.
Friends. The outside.

BENJAMIN
I've asked. They always point me
to Anna.

REGAN
Always smiling. Always calm. Have
you noticed she never answers
directly? And she never lets you
say goodbye first.

That lands heavy.

BENJAMIN
Like a script.

REGAN

Yeah.

She reaches up, pulls down a paper crane.

REGAN (CONT'D)

Take it. Sometimes it's nice to have something real to hold onto.

Benjamin takes it carefully, like it might collapse in his hands.

BENJAMIN

Thanks.

REGAN

You're not alone here, Benjamin.

He smiles, barely. And it's the first real one.

INT. COMMON ROOM - LATER

BENJAMIN enters to find OTTO near the window, wearing a weathered military coat and "polishing" imaginary medals on his chest with a handkerchief made of gauze.

OTTO

You're late for debriefing. The Kaiser's spies are in the vents. Don't pretend you haven't heard them.

BENJAMIN

I think that's the air system.

OTTO

That's what they want you to think.

A SMALL FIGURE sits cross-legged on the floor in the far corner. Still as stone. Watching.

A boy. Maybe fifteen, but small for his age. Dark curls. Pale skin. Slight build. Barefoot. He stares directly at Benjamin with quiet intensity.

BENJAMIN

(quietly, to Otto)
Who's the kid?

OTTO

(doesn't look)
Little menace is what he is.

Benjamin turns his attention back to Otto.

BENJAMIN
So, Otto... what year is it?

OTTO
1917. If we don't reinforce the
east corridor by dawn, we're
compromised.

He lifts an invisible field radio to his mouth.

OTTO (CONT'D)
Copy that. I have eyes on the new
recruit. He looks soft, but he's
got potential.

Benjamin raises an eyebrow amused, a little unnerved.

AMBER (O.S.)
He's not soft. Just unbaked.

AMBER enters, holding her twine-wrapped cat like it's
breathing.

AMBER (CONT'D)
Otto's harmless. He's just tuned
to a different channel. Or maybe a
different timeline. I haven't
decided.

OTTO
I'm not tuned. I'm stationed.

AMBER
Whatever helps you cope, soldier.

She plops down beside Benjamin.

AMBER (CONT'D)
He might've been here the longest.
Or time just loops for him. Like
VHS rewind.

BENJAMIN
Does anyone ever leave?

Otto and Amber exchange a glance.

OTTO
Only in pieces.

AMBER
Or shadows. Depends on how much
you remember.

BENJAMIN
You're both incredibly comforting.

AMBER
This pudding is definitely
sentient.

REGAN
That's why you have to eat it
fast. Before it grows legs.

OTTO
I confiscated a meatball last
week. It's under surveillance.

They all laugh genuinely. For a brief moment, it feels like
normalcy.

BENJAMIN
(quietly, to Regan)
How do you make this bearable?

REGAN
You don't.

He nods, grateful. She nudges her tray toward him.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Also, bribe people with pudding.

Suddenly, the overhead lights flicker once, twice, then
snap to black for a split second.

When they return, everything is where it was. Except
Amber's cat is gone from the table.

She freezes. Looks down at her hands, then under the table.

AMBER
He was right here.

BENJAMIN
You sure?

AMBER
I don't lose him. He doesn't
leave.

Everyone quiets.

From across the cafeteria, Jace watches them. Leaning
against the wall.

He tilts his head slightly then, walks away.

Cut to Malachai sitting in the floor. In his lap is Amber's stuffed cat.

MALACHAI
He wanted to see the hallway. I
took him for a walk.

AMBER (O.S.)
What the hell?

Amber storms in and sees the cat. Freezes.

MALACHAI holds it out with both hands, like an offering.

MALACHAI
He was lonely. He told me so.

Amber snatches the cat -- quickly checks it. It's unharmed, but now wrapped in red thread, tied in precise loops.

AMBER
You don't get to touch him.

Malachai SCREAMS.

Everyone jolts. Then silence.

Malachai tilts his head slightly.

MALACHAI
Are you listening? She is.

He stands. Walks away, barefoot. Whispers something to the wall as he passes it.

Benjamin turns to Otto.

BENJAMIN
What is wrong with him?

OTTO(HUSHED)
Some say he's been here longer
than the floorboards.

BENJAMIN
But, he's just a kid.

Benjamin watches Malachai disappear around the corner.

CUT TO: Amber clutching her cat, unsettled.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. ANNA'S OFFICE - EVENING

The room glows with flickering amber light. Anna moves like she's following choreography only she can hear. Deliberate. Silent. Sacred.

Benjamin sits rigid in a high-backed chair across from her. His fingers dig into the carved arms of the seat. Symbols etched into the wood glow faintly when touched.

BENJAMIN

You always say hello. Never hi.
Never hey. You don't have to be so
formal. We're all crazy here.

ANNA

Words matter.

She lights another candle, gaze unbroken.

ANNA (CONT'D)

Tell me how you have been since
you arrived.

BENJAMIN

Uneasy. Feels like there's
something in the walls. A noise
that isn't just pipes or vents.

ANNA

And what do you believe that noise
means?

BENJAMIN

I believe it means I'm not alone
here. Really not alone. Other than
the other crazies.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)

So, is that what this is? Just a
bunch of feelings?

ANNA

No. It's a place where your mind
shows you what it avoids. Where
healing begins.

BENJAMIN

I don't need riddles. I need
answers. I want to talk to my
sister. I want to leave.

ANNA

I don't decide that.

BENJAMIN
That's not an answer. What does
that even mean?? You really aren't
very good at this.

She smiles. Vague.

ANNA
Okay, Benjamin. Goodbye.

The candle beside Benjamin extinguishes itself.

A beat of silence.

He stands, eyes darting toward the door.

BENJAMIN
That's it?

No answer. Anna just stares. And then turns her head
slightly, as if hearing a voice no one else does.

Her lips move soundlessly. Then

ANNA (SOFTLY)
Someone new is listening.

INT. HALLWAY OUTSIDE THE OFFICE - MOMENTS LATER

Benjamin exits, rattled. The hallway is dark. Unusually so.

Whispers echo faintly. Not words. Just tones. He turns. No
one there.

He picks up his pace. Passing one door at a time. The doors
are marked A, B, C, D.

Then stops. At the end of the hallway, Lucy stands. Still.
Watching.

She takes a step forward.

BENJAMIN
Hey. Are you okay?

No answer.

She raises one hand. Her palm is covered in black marker. A
symbol matching the one carved into Anna's desk.

LUCY
You weren't supposed to say
goodbye.

Her voice is delicate. Almost childlike.

BENJAMIN

What?

LUCY

She was still talking.

Benjamin turns to look behind him. The hallway is now completely empty.

When he turns back, Lucy is gone.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. AMBER'S ROOM - NIGHT

Amber's room is dim and strange. Childhood clutter mixed with neglect. Tattered lace curtains flutter, though the window is closed.

Amber sits cross-legged on the floor. The twine cat rests in her lap.

A soft knock.

BENJAMIN

Hey. Regan said I'd find you here.

AMBER

And look at that. You did.

He lingers in the doorway.

BENJAMIN

She said you might know something about the noises. About this place. Is it haunted? I know that sounds crazy.

Amber pats the floor beside her.

AMBER

Sit. Quiet now. They listen through the vents.

Benjamin lowers himself beside her, careful not to crush a drawing of a spiral made of teeth.

AMBER (CONT'D)
I've been here longer than some. I
used to think it was a dream. But
I remember things now.

BENJAMIN
Remember what?

AMBER
How easy it is to disappear.

BENJAMIN
I'm sure your family hasn't--

She cuts him off with a look. Her eyes shimmer, then
harden.

AMBER
No. Maybe they're ashamed. There
are doors here. Ones that aren't
meant to open. But I found one.

BENJAMIN
How do you know that?

Benjamin raises an eyebrow. Skeptical.

AMBER
Because everything feels wrong
near them. And it smells funny. I
swear they pump pot through the
vents to keep us chill.

Benjamin chuckles.

BENJAMIN
And you still went close?

AMBER
I didn't mean to. I just stopped
there one day. And it felt like
standing too close to something
hot.

BENJAMIN
Did it open?

AMBER
No.

A low hum starts in the walls. Subtle at first. Then
louder.

Amber closes her eyes and tilts her head. Listening.

AMBER (CONT'D)
It's shifting again.

She presses her palm to the floor.

The humming deepens for a moment, like the room reacts.

AMBER (CONT'D)
Tomorrow, I'll show you something.

She looks directly at him. No smile. No twitch.

Just the weight of certainty.

INT. OUTDOOR COURTYARD - DAY

A rare patch of sunlight spills into a stone-walled courtyard. Weeds burst through cracks in the concrete. It's the only place that feels alive.

Regan and Benjamin sit on a weathered bench. A breeze moves through her curls.

REGAN
I used to think I was unlovable.

Benjamin pauses.

BENJAMIN
You're not.

REGAN
It's easy to say that. But when
you hate your own reflection.

She breathes deeply. Watches a butterfly land on her knee, then fly away.

REGAN (CONT'D)
I never expected to find a friend
in here. Someone who makes it
easier.

BENJAMIN
You're the only reason I haven't
completely lost it.

REGAN
Look around.

They both laugh, but it's tired.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Sometimes I imagine walking out of
here and not feeling watched.

BENJAMIN
Yeah? What would your first outing
be as a free woman?

REGAN
I'd walk into a diner. Order
waffles. And not apologize for
wanting extra syrup.

They both chuckle, a real moment of levity.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Do you think it's possible, really
possible, to ever leave this
place?

BENJAMIN
Why not? We didn't hurt anyone.
Maybe we get better. Maybe we
don't. But we won't stay forever.

She rests her head on his shoulder.

They sit in quiet.

Then, something moves across the edge of the courtyard.
Just behind the hedge wall. A shadow, too tall to be human,
slips out of view.

Benjamin lifts his head.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
Did you see that?

REGAN
See what?

He stares for a moment longer.

BENJAMIN
Never mind.

Regan shifts closer, eyes closed.

A crumpled paper crane blows across the concrete and stops
at Benjamin's foot, as if placed there.

CONTINUED - INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - NIGHT

DIM. NARROW. INDUSTRIAL.

Benjamin follows Amber and Regan down a hallway lined with storage doors and utility panels. This part of the building feels older, like it wasn't built with the rest of the hospital.

BENJAMIN

Are we even allowed down here?

AMBER

Are we allowed anywhere? Doesn't stop them from watching.

She stops abruptly in front of a steel utility door with no knob, just a flat plate of metal and an uneven seam.

AMBER (CONT'D)

This wasn't always here.

BENJAMIN

What do you mean?

AMBER

I've walked this hall a hundred times. One day, boom. It's just here.

She kneels. Runs her fingers along the floor in front of it.

AMBER (CONT'D)

Feel this?

Benjamin kneels and touches the tile and shivers. The air near the door is cold, like standing next to a freezer that hums. Almost alive.

AMBER (CONT'D)

People say it's where the ones who vanish go.

BENJAMIN

You believe that? That makes no sense.

REGAN (SARCASM)

Yeah, they're just storing bodies in a closet.

AMBER

I just listen to others. I'm not saying it's true.

She takes a twine bracelet off her wrist and lays it on the floor in front of the door.

They all wait.

REGAN
What are you do-

AMBER
Shh!

For a long, terrible second nothing.
The bracelet slides forward on its own, as if pulled.

BENJAMIN
Jesus!

Amber whispers, eyes locked on the seam:

AMBER
It's listening to us.

A faint, high-pitched ringing starts in their ears.

A DEEP KNOCK.

From the other side of the door.

Three slow, deliberate thuds. Benjamin stumbles back.

BENJAMIN
Nope. No. We're not doing this.

REGAN
What the hell? Why have you never
showed me this?

AMBER
I told you I'd show you something
real, Benjamin.

AMBER (CONT'D)
(To Regan)
Because you never asked.

She picks up the bracelet and pockets it calmly.

AMBER (CONT'D)
They don't like being ignored.

She turns and walks down the hallway.

Benjamin stays frozen -- staring at the door.

Behind him, faint scratching sounds echo from the seam.

INT. ANNA'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Benjamin sits in the velvet chair once again. A dense fog of sage smoke coils through the dim room. A circle of crystals surrounds a small candle that flickers erratically.

The air feels warmer than it should.

Anna enters without a sound.

ANNA

Hello.

BENJAMIN

Why are you always burning something?

He waves his hand through the smoke, irritated.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)

You realize it reeks, right?

ANNA

Focus. Boundaries.

(pause)

The same reason I ask questions.
To make you look inward.

BENJAMIN

You ever try answering any?

Anna sits slowly. Between them, a small hourglass filled with black sand. She flips it. Begins writing something in her leather-bound notebook.

ANNA

Do you rest? Are you comfortable?

BENJAMIN

I keep having vivid dreams.
Symbols everywhere. A circle. A
line through it. Rooms that twist
and turn. I think this place is
messing with me.

ANNA

People use symbols when they can't
say things out loud.

BENJAMIN

I need more than riddles.

ANNA
I can't answer your questions,
Benjamin. I wasn't there.

Benjamin leans forward, jaw tight, eyes sharp.

BENJAMIN
Stop talking like a fortune
cookie.
(slams palm on the desk)
Tell me why the walls make noise.
Why Amber says we're not supposed
to be here.

Anna looks up. Not startled. Just still.

ANNA
I don't know why you're here. I
really don't.

She lights another stick of incense. Murmurs a phrase under
her breath, syllables that don't belong to any recognizable
language.

Benjamin's eyes narrow.

ANNA (CONT'D)
Because some places are built to
hold, not to heal. Some places
aren't meant to fix people.

BENJAMIN
So we're prisoners?

ANNA
You are free to leave whenever you
would like.

She stands.

ANNA (CONT'D)
I have to run.
(pause)
Goodbye.

She turns her back.

BENJAMIN
No. Not this time. You're saying I
can leave? I'm not being held
here? Answer me.

He grabs the hourglass from the table, lifts it, and hurls
it against the wall.

CRASH.

Black sand spills across the floor.

The flame on the candle flashes BLUE, then PURPLE.

The flame on the candle flashes blue, then purple. The smoke halts, suspended in midair.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)

Answer me!

He rushes to the door. When he throws it open, he doesn't find the hallway.

Instead, a mirror version of the office. The same chair. The same symbols. Empty. A flicker of movement. A reflection of himself seated calmly in the chair. But it's not him. It's still.

He slams the door shut again.

The real office now looks faded. Wrong. Like a bad copy.

The candle now burns blue. The wax runs in unnatural directions, sideways, upward.

On the desk, in place of the hourglass: A new drawing.

A circle with a line through it, scrawled in wax like a child did it.

Benjamin stares at it, breath quickening.

A sound behind him.

LUCY (O.S.)

You cracked it.

Benjamin turns. Lucy stands in the corner of the room, silent, pale, fingers dripping wax. Eyes unreadable.

LUCY (CONT'D)

But you're not ready for what's inside.

She vanishes as if she was never there.

Benjamin's breath catches.

He slowly sinks into the velvet chair. Stares at the symbol on the desk, burned into the wood like it was always there.

He laughs once, bitter and hollow. Then presses both hands to his face.

BENJAMIN (QUIETLY, TO HIMSELF)
I don't know what's real anymore.
I don't know where I am. I need to
speak to my family.

Tears slip through his fingers, silent.

He looks toward the empty doorway where Anna disappeared and speaks softly, broken:

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
Please. Just tell me the truth.
Even if it kills me.

Nothing.

Just the drip of wax and the low hum in the walls.

FADE OUT.

INT. EAST WING - NIGHT

Amber leads Benjamin and Regan down a long-forgotten hallway. Dust hangs in the air. The walls pulse faintly.

AMBER
No one's supposed to know this is
here.

BENJAMIN
You really do know a lot about
this place. Why haven't you
figured out how to leave yet?

AMBER
I just assumed I had to do my
time. Whatever that means.

BENJAMIN
Why are you even here?

Amber pauses. Looking ahead as if trying to remember.

REGAN
She doesn't know. I've asked her
before.

She pushes aside a tall, grimy chalkboard. Behind it, nearly consumed by shadow, is a door with no handle.

It groans open.

INT. HIDDEN RECORD ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Rows of rusted metal shelves. Mold-blackened files. Cassette tapes, unlabeled, some warped from time. A cracked intercom speaker hisses softly.

REGAN
This looks like patient records.

AMBER
The kind they don't want shared.

Benjamin runs his fingers across the dusty labels. Stops.

BENJAMIN
This is mine.

He pulls the folder. Nearly every line is redacted.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
This makes no sense.

AMBER
Some of them are fake. Yours
doesn't look like it. That's why
they keep watching you.

A sudden gasp from Regan.

REGAN
What is that?

In the corner, behind discarded linens and rusted stools, a trapdoor half-covered by a tarp.

BENJAMIN
A basement?

AMBER
Oh, I'm going in.

The humming returns, louder here. Pressure builds in the walls.

Amber places a hand on the trapdoor, eyes fluttering closed.

AMBER (CONT'D)
Whatever's down there, it's
probably worse than the rest of
this place.

REGAN
You and the creepy shit.

BENJAMIN
We're already too far in not to.
Besides, what else do we have to
do? Finger paint?

He kneels and lifts the trapdoor.

A burst of cold air hits them. The scent of wet stone and
something forgotten.

INT. TRAPDOOR CHAMBER - NIGHT

The three descend narrow, creaking stairs. Only Regan's
flashlight lights the way, flickering.

They enter a chamber that shouldn't exist. Carved stone
instead of cement. Uneven.

REGAN
This place gives me chills.

BENJAMIN
It doesn't feel like a basement.
It feels wrong.

AMBER
It's not a basement. It's older.
This was here before the hospital.

BENJAMIN
I swear to god if I find out this
place was built on an ancient
burial ground!

They move deeper, stepping over cracked tiles etched with
symbols. Cobwebs cling to the walls. The air vibrates
softly.

Regan stops.

REGAN
Look at this.

A wall of tally marks. Hundreds, maybe thousands. Uneven.
Carved deep.

BENJAMIN
Someone kept count. Did Jace do
this?

AMBER
Of what? Days here? Days until he
leaves?

Suddenly the flashlight dies.

Complete darkness. Amber trips and falls.

BENJAMIN
Amber? Regan?

AMBER (O.S.)
I'm here. I'm on the floor, but
I'm here.

REGAN (O.S.)
Something's in here with us.

A sound brushes past them. Like breathing, but wrong. Then
silence.

Benjamin's hand brushes the wall. It pulses beneath his
fingers.

BENJAMIN
Let's go back. NOW!

AMBER
Wait. What is this?

She feels along the floor. Her hand closes around a small
rusted tin box.

Inside: old Polaroids (faces scratched out), a small
porcelain doll, and a strange carved object; wooden,
oblong.

They all freeze.

REGAN
Why would this be down here?

BENJAMIN
We need to show the others.

As they move toward the stairs, a sound fills the chamber.
Not a voice.

Amber clutches the box tighter as they run back upstairs.

INT. EAST WING - CONTINUOUS

They emerge breathless. Benjamin looks back one last time.

The trapdoor is closed. He didn't close it.

CONTINUED - INT. COMMON ROOM - LATER THAT NIGHT

The group is gathered in a semicircle: Amber, Benjamin, Regan, Otto, Carmilla, and Jace, who leans against the wall, arms crossed.

The rusted tin box sits on the table. The objects inside are laid out: Polaroids, the doll, and the glass-eyed wooden artifact.

CARMILLA

This is a ritual box.

AMBER

We found it in a chamber under the East Wing. A place that's not even on the map.

BENJAMIN

It's older than the hospital. There were symbols. Walls covered in tally marks. Someone was counting something.

They all look at Jace.

JACE

Don't look at me. I'm not going down there.

OTTO

Tally marks aren't always days. Sometimes they're debts.

JACE

You should've left it there.

BENJAMIN

Did you know about it?

JACE

No, but I know enough to leave sealed things sealed.

REGAN

What is it?

CARMILLA

Memory. In pieces. Something they tried to get rid of. Or forget.

AMBER
Someone did not want it found,
that's for sure.

BENJAMIN
(sharply)
Forget what? That we're being kept
here? That this place doesn't make
sense?

He slams a hand on the table. Everyone flinches.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
Can someone rein in the crazy for
two minutes? Anyone? Just stop
talking around it. I want the
truth.

JACE
You're in the wrong place for
that, Price.

OTTO
Truth's a dangerous thing in a
locked ward.

CARMILLA
Especially one that lost its key.

Carmilla sips the tea she always seems to have.

Benjamin takes an annoyed breath. His eyes flick to Regan,
who's watching him.

BENJAMIN
We can't stay passive anymore. Not
after that.

He looks at the box, his hands trembling.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
We found something. We can't just
pretend we didn't.

AMBER
No one's pretending. But you have
to understand.

She looks around. Voice lowering.

AMBER (CONT'D)
Whoever's watching saw us down
there.

A long beat.

Lucy appears in the doorway.

Still. Barefoot. Eyes unreadable.

Everyone turns toward her. No one speaks.

She steps into the room, silent. Reaches toward the Polaroids then stops.

LUCY
You won't like what's missing.

She turns, walks away.

JACE
(under his breath)
Of course she shows up now.

BENJAMIN
What did she mean?

CARMILLA
Maybe not everything in that box
came back with you.

Without warning, MALACHAI launches himself at Benjamin's back. Arms and legs wrap around him. The room gasps.

MALACHAI
(whispers in Benjamin's ear) Maybe
it's me. Maybe I did it.

BENJAMIN
Get off me, you fucking spider
monkey!

Malachai lets go and scurries under a table.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
Jesus Christ. Someone put a leash
on that kid.

FADE OUT.

INT. COMMON ROOM - DAY

A heavy silence. Dim light filters through stained-glass panels that didn't exist yesterday.

The group sits in a loose circle: Benjamin, Amber, Regan, Otto, Carmilla, and now, a new presence.

HAROLD (60s), white button-down stained with ink, suspenders twisted, a large notebook filled with chaotic diagrams in his lap. He mutters quietly to himself as he draws overlapping circles.

Benjamin sets the rusted tin box on the table. The others lean in.

Malachai is hanging upside down from a pipe, legs hooked, arms dangling, staring directly at Benjamin.

OTTO
(mutters, crossing
himself)
Saint Michael defend us.

CARMILLA
(gripping her rosary, dances
around) It's awake.

Benjamin points to his eyes, then back at Malachai as if to say "I'm watching you."

Malachai hisses as Benjamin pulls his attention back to the others.

BENJAMIN
This was underneath the East Wing.
Buried. Behind a false wall.
Beneath a trapdoor.

AMBER
It wasn't just dust and old files.
There was something down there.

REGAN
We heard shit. I felt watched.

HAROLD
(scribbling)
Old frequencies. Not language.
Something repeating.

They turn to him.

BENJAMIN
Who are you again?

HAROLD
Harold. I draw things so I don't
forget them.
(pauses, then solemnly)
I saw this box in a dream once.
Except it was made of metal.

AMBER
That... tracks.

Suddenly, the door creaks open.

Anna enters, unnervingly serene. Her footsteps make no sound.

ANNA
Hello. Good morning.

She spots the box instantly. Her expression flickers, then resets.

ANNA (CONT'D)
What have you been up to?

She approaches, peers inside. Her fingers graze the carved object.

The room dims. Light bulbs flicker.

CARMILLA
(whispers)
The flame dipped. And there's no flame.

ANNA
Have you been busy?

BENJAMIN
We found this. In a locked chamber under the foundation of this place.

ANNA
I don't like this.

BENJAMIN
You knew it was there. You let us wander into it.

ANNA
I told you, some questions I can't answer.

She closes the box slowly and lifts it beneath her arm like something precious.

BENJAMIN
Well, can you answer ONE question?
This is YOUR job.

ANNA
Please don't push this.
(beat)

I don't know what's down there.
She turns. Fearful.

ANNA (CONT'D)
This session is over.

A long pause.

Then:

ANNA (CONT'D)
Goodbye.

She exits. The room holds its breath.

AMBER
Did anyone else feel that?

REGAN
Like air was sucked out of the room.

OTTO
Whatever that is, I want nothing to do with it. It feels wrong.

HAROLD
Time jumped when she touched it. Did you feel that gap?

BENJAMIN
She's hiding something. Whatever this is, it's not just a hospital..

CARMILLA
What does it want?
(giggles)
(whispers)
To keep us.

HAROLD
It doesn't let things finish.

Harold doesn't look up, continues drawing.

Benjamin drops his head onto the desk, frustrated.

Regan pats him on the back.

REGAN
There there.

OTTO
We shouldn't push further.

BENJAMIN
But we're in it. We're already in whatever this is.

(pause)

He stares at the door where Anna vanished.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
And we're still part of it. Like
it or not.

CONTINUED - INT. COMMON ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Benjamin continues staring at the door.

The others are quiet.

Harold hasn't moved. He draws faster now. Wild arcs, tall
shadow figures next to stick people with crossed-out faces.

HAROLD
(tapping the paper)
It's always the same. The tall
ones come when things get too
close. The door opens wrong.

REGAN
What door?

HAROLD
Not like a normal door. It opens
wrong.

He flips the page. Points to a rough sketch of the common
room. The chairs are drawn upside down.

HAROLD (CONT'D)
I've been here before. But I
hadn't arrived yet.

AMBER
Harold, what does that mean?

HAROLD
It means I should have left. I
don't know why I keep coming back.

A long silence.

BENJAMIN
You think we're next?

Harold slowly looks up at him. For a rare moment, his voice
is calm. Almost lucid.

HAROLD
You're not next.
(beat)
You're the reason the order
breaks.

CARMILLA
He doesn't belong to it.

HAROLD
Not yet. But he will.

OTTO
(to Harold)
Okay, old man. Maybe take a
breath.

HAROLD
I did. Didn't help.

Benjamin kneels next to him.

BENJAMIN
Harold... what are they trying to
do to us?

HAROLD
Not trying. Doing. You should
interfere.

REGAN
Doing what?

HAROLD
They're keeping us. For
safekeeping. They aren't healing
us.
(beat)
Did anyone get meds today?

Harold stares ahead. Then returns to his drawing humming
quietly and off-key.

FADE OUT.

INT. REGAN'S ROOM - NIGHT

Regan paces, chewing her thumbnail. Benjamin sits
cross-legged on her bed, flipping through one of Amber's
hand-drawn maps of the facility.

REGAN
She just left. Just like that. No
explanation. No warning.

BENJAMIN
She knew it was there. That means
she's been lying to all of us.

AMBER (O.S.)
Not just lying. Hiding things.

Amber enters, breathless, holding a tattered book bound in red twine.

AMBER (CONT'D)
She keeps records of every object
she collects.

Benjamin opens it, pages filled with sketches of strange objects, paired with patient initials and cryptic notes. The final page is mostly blank, save for one line:

"The medium doesn't realize she is the channel."

REGAN
What does that mean?

BENJAMIN
You think one of us is a...
medium?

AMBER
Maybe.

Suddenly, the lights flicker. A sharp buzz hums from the vent above.

BENJAMIN
It's starting again.

REGAN
We need to move it. If she feels
something's off, it's only a
matter of time before someone else
stumbles onto it.

AMBER
And figure out what it is.

They exchange a glance, fear mixed with resolve.

BENJAMIN
And do what? Some old Polaroids
aren't the answer to whatever the
hell is going on.

AMBER
No. But it wasn't hidden by
accident.

INT. COMMON ROOM - LATER THAT NIGHT

The group regathers. The room is dim, thunder rumbling beyond the cracked windows.

Otto paces in the corner, agitated. Carmilla clutches her rosary tighter than ever. Harold is sprawled on the floor with his notebook, sketching rapidly.

BENJAMIN

We wait until Anna's rounds are over. Then we go to her office.

REGAN

If anyone's watching, it'll be quiet after rounds. That's our window. I'm going to bed until this shit is over.

HAROLD

(tapping a page)

You open the wrong door... things come back wrong.

AMBER

Then we knock first.

OTTO

No. No! It's a trap! The place lets you think you found something.

AMBER

Otto--calm down.

OTTO

You don't get it! I saw what happened to the others who asked too many questions. They vanish!

CARMILLA

Hush. Fear feeds what's listening.

HAROLD

Sometimes fear is the correct response.

Otto kicks over a chair.

Everyone flinches. Even Harold stops drawing.

BENJAMIN

Otto, we're on your side. We're all trying to figure this out.

OTTO

You weren't here before. And it's starting again.

REGAN

You need to sit. Please.

Otto backs into the far corner. Eyes wide. Mumbles incoherently.

OTTO
It's inside the walls. Watching.

HAROLD
(softly)
It listens, too.

AMBER
We need to move. Now. Before this
place swallows another one of us.

BENJAMIN
Let's go.

They begin filing out -- Amber, Regan, Carmilla, Harold
trailing behind, stuffing his notebook into his shirt.

As the exit the common room, find MALACHAI sitting in a
chalk-drawn circle of tally's, Y's and N's alternating
around the edge.

MALACHAI
Wanna play? You ask, I answer. But
no touching.

Benjamin steps closer.

MALACHAI (CONT'D)
Careful. If you lie in the circle,
it grabs you.

He taps his head.

MALACHAI (CONT'D)
That's how I got stuck.

BENJAMIN
I'm really trying not to judge
right now.

Regan grabs Benjamin's arm and leads him along.

REGAN
Come on. Leave the wild child
alone.

HAROLD
If you see the hallway double back
on itself... run toward it. Not
away.

Otto doesn't answer. He rocks in place, whispering.

OTTO
They are going to get us all
killed...

He scratches at the wall with his fingernail.

The others disappear into the hallway. Thunder rolls louder.

Otto stops scratching. Looks at his finger. Blood.

FADE OUT.

INT. HALLWAY OUTSIDE ANNA'S OFFICE - NIGHT

The group creeps through the dim corridor -- Benjamin, Regan, Amber, Carmilla, and Harold -- silent but wide-eyed.

Lights flicker like they're blinking. The floor creaks behind them, though no one is there.

Harold jogs up from the far hallway, breathless, clutching his notebook to his chest.

HAROLD

Wait. Don't leave me behind this time.

BENJAMIN

There.

He points to the door marked DR. ANNA.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)

It's locked.

AMBER

I can pick it.

She kneels and produces a bent hairpin from inside her sleeve. The others keep watch. Harold hums quietly, something out of tune.

REGAN

Well aren't you the little criminal? Hurry. I don't like this hallway.

CARMILLA

I think it's... longer than it was.

CLICK. The door opens.

INT. ANNA'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

The room is darker than before. Candles burn low, casting warped shadows that seem to shift when no one moves.

Crystals vibrate softly on their shelves. Papers flutter even without wind.

BENJAMIN
Check everything.

They scatter.

Amber pulls books from the shelf, flipping pages.

Regan opens a drawer; patient files, half-burned.

Harold stares at the ceiling, scribbling invisible symbols in the air.

Carmilla crosses herself and murmurs.

AMBER
(quietly)
What's in here?

She lifts a loose floorboard beneath the woven rug. Nothing underneath. No box. No object.

Just scuff marks.

Dust disturbed recently.

The faint outline where something used to sit.

BENJAMIN
It's been opened.

He pulls it out. Inside: the photographs, the doll, but the wooden object is gone.

REGAN
Recently?

AMBER
Yeah. Not carefully, either.

She runs her fingers along the edge of the wood.

AMBER (CONT'D)
Someone didn't want to leave it here.

BENJAMIN
Or didn't want us finding it here.

REGAN
What is she hiding?

Benjamin searches behind the desk and finds a journal, bound in leather. He flips through it.

A low hum begins. Subtle. Almost electrical.

The candles tremble. Flames stretch unnaturally tall, then go out.

Darkness.

HAROLD
(shaking)
They're watching. They've always watched. We stayed too long.

AMBER
We need to go.

BENJAMIN
Wait--

A whisper, close to Benjamin's ear. No breath. No voice.
Not words.

Benjamin flinches.

CARMILLA
What did you feel?

BENJAMIN
Like... something noticed I was looking.

Everyone goes still.

Harold nods once.

HAROLD
You'll hear more now. That's the cost of being here. That's how they drive you mad.
(pause)
Well, Madder.
(thinks)
More mad?

They move for the door.

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

--And are met with a hallway that is no longer the same.
The floor appears longer, stretching ahead like a tunnel.
Doors shift slightly when stared at.

CARMILLA
Oh God. It's shifting.

REGAN
Oh god, what have we done?

They start running.

The further they move, the more warped the space becomes.
Paintings hang upside down, light bulbs flicker with
whispers instead of buzz, a door appears, then vanishes as
they approach.

They reach an intersection.

HAROLD
Wait--wait--don't go left.

BENJAMIN
Why?

HAROLD
Left is yesterday. If you go back,
you won't be you anymore.

For some reason this makes sense. They go right.

As they run, the lights behind them shatter one by one.

BENJAMIN
Keep going!

AMBER
Where are we even going?

CARMILLA
Anywhere but here!

As they round the final turn, the hallway abruptly snaps
back to normal; bright lights, soft hum of the vents.

Silence.

They stop, panting. No one speaks for a moment.

Then:

HAROLD
Next time, it won't reset. I've
seen it.

CARMILLA
It doesn't like it when we're
naughty.

Camilla says sing-songy with a wild smile.

Benjamin slides down the wall, out of breath.

FADE OUT.

INT. LOWER CORRIDORS - NIGHT

The corridor pulses with red light. The floor underfoot
breathes just slightly. Benjamin, Amber, Regan, and Harold
walk through the halls.

AMBER
We're not in the same wing
anymore. This place... It's
rewriting itself.

REGAN
This is giving serious hell mouth
vibes. Buffy would not be
impressed.

Benjamin and Amber fist bump without looking at each other.

BENJAMIN
Nice.
(then)
We need to stay together. Keep
moving.

They advance. Shadows move independently of them.

INT. WIDE CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

The group stops short.

At the center of the room, the floor is damaged.

Circles scratched over older circles. Lines cut through them again and again. Not fresh, Layered.

AMBER
This wasn't done by one person.

REGAN
Or all at once. A low sound
builds. Not a growl. Not a voice.

More like feedback. The shadows in the room misalign,
lagging behind their movements by half a second. Amber
steps forward.

AMBER
That's not one of us.

REGAN
Demon. That is 100% a demon.

BENJAMIN
This is where people get stuck.

The sound spikes.

The walls flex inward; not collapsing, just correcting.

HAROLD
(panicked)
We're too close. It doesn't like
witnesses.

The floor shifts beneath them.

BENJAMIN
MOVE!

INT. HIDDEN STAIRCASE - MOMENTS LATER

They slam through a broken archway into a narrow stone
stairwell. Dust and heat.

INT. UNDERGROUND CHAMBER - MOMENTS LATER

A wide circular room, candlelit. Every wall is carved with
symbols Amber once sketched.

Inside it, the wooden object rests, inert. Ordinary. Out of
place.

CARMILLA
This is where they practiced. Over
and over. Until it worked.

AMBER
Maybe its an access point. Or
summoning chamber.

REGAN
So... weren't dropped here. We
were placed here? And who the fuck
is being summoned??

BENJAMIN
I think they're bringing them
here. On purpose. Maybe not the
purpose they want you to think,
but A purpose.

The door slams shut behind them. The hum returns louder.
Almost angry.

Carmilla rocks gently, smiling at something only she sees
while dancing and swaying gently.

REGAN
Oh God --

Benjamin sees someone standing across the circle.

It's him. Staring back. Wearing the same shirt.

BENJAMIN
(quietly)
...what the hell?

The reflection blinks, but he doesn't. Then disappears as
if it was never there.

CARMILLA
You looked past the curtain,
didn't you? What did it show you,
Benjamin?

BENJAMIN
Nothing. Just... this place is
getting to me.

HAROLD
(very calm)
They show us ourselves when it's
almost time.

Everyone looks at him.

BENJAMIN
Time for what?

Harold smiles gently, like it's already too late.

HAROLD
For remembering who we are.

The humming builds again, vibrating their bones.

The candles gutter out one by one.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. UNDERGROUND CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

The group enters a low-ceilinged room carved out of stone and concrete.

Not ritualistic. Institutional. Old. Forgotten.

A metal cart sits against one wall.

A CRT television rests on top, thick glass screen dusty but intact. Shelves line the walls. Hundreds of VHS tapes.

Handwritten labels. Dates. Names. The hum here is constant. Electrical. Uneasy. Amber stops short.

AMBER
This isn't a chamber. This is
storage.

Regan steps closer to the shelves.

REGAN
Storage for what?

Benjamin scans the labels. Names. Initials. Room numbers. Then he freezes.

He pulls one tape from the shelf. Written in black marker: BENJAMIN PRICE. A date underneath. Recent

BENJAMIN
...That's me.

No one jokes.

Harold steps back like the air just shifted.

HAROLD
(low)
That means it's already been
recorded.

Carmilla tilts her head, smiling faintly.

CARMILLA
They keep what we won't look at.

Benjamin moves to the TV.

REGAN
Ben, maybe don't--

He slides the tape in.

The machine CLUNKS. Whirs.

Static. Then image.

ON SCREEN - BENJAMIN'S APARTMENT
The footage is grainy. Fixed
angle. Corner of the room.

Benjamin on-screen moves through the space, packing a box.

It's real. Ordinary. Too quiet.

A phone vibrates on the table.

Voicemail plays through tinny speakers.

BENJAMIN
This is my apartment...

A scene plays out. Benjamin packing a box, a voicemail from his sister playing.

VOICEMAIL (V.O.)
Ben, please just call me back. I'm
worried about you.

He watches himself ignore the phone, isolate, spiral. Lets the phone stop vibrating. In the room, real Benjamin can't look away.

AMBER
They've been recording us.

On-screen Benjamin rewinds the tape.

Watches himself rewind it again.

The image glitches.

Now the on-screen Benjamin looks straight at the camera.
At them. The real Benjamin steps back.

BENJAMIN
I didn't consent to this and I
never did that. Turn it off.

The TV ejects the tape violently. It clatters to the floor.
Lights flicker. Another tape rattles on the shelf. Then
another. Harold covers his ears.

HAROLD
They don't erase anything. They
just keep it looping.

Regan grabs Benjamin's arm.

REGAN
This isn't therapy. This is
surveillance.

The TV flickers. A tape on the shelf beside the machine
SLIDES FORWARD slightly.

Just enough to be seen.

This one slides halfway out.

Written on it: REGAN

Regan stiffens.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Oh god. No. Nope. Not doing that.

Regan reaches for the VCR. Amber stops her.

AMBER
Maybe you have to see it through.
Some sort of immersion therapy?

REGAN
I don't need to see it. I already
lived it.

The TV turns back on. Static.

ON THE TV: HOSPITAL ROOM - NIGHT
Regan lies unconscious in a bed.

Nurses argue quietly near the door.

NURSE #1 (V.O.)
They're saying it was accidental.

NURSE #2 (V.O.)
Doesn't look accidental to me.

In the hallway beyond -- Regan's MOTHER sobs into her hands.

REGAN
Oh god.

She backs away from the screen.

AMBER
This isn't treatment. This is evidence.

The static does not stop.

The image bleeds past the edges of the screen.

The sound hums through the walls.

Everyone else hears noise.

Regan hears words.

She presses her hands to her ears.

REGAN
(quiet, scared)
It's not just sound. It's...
behind it. Like it knows I'm
listening. Its so loud.

BENJAMIN
What do you mean "behind it"?

The TV flicker harder. Static spikes. The image warps only when Regan speaks. Benjamin notices. Regan puts her hands over her ears.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
Stop
(to Amber)
Do you see that?

AMBER
See what?

Benjamin steps closer to the TV. Nothing changes. He guides Regan by the shoulders to take one step back. The static drops instantly. Everyone clocks it.

REGAN
Why did it stop?

BENJAMIN
Regan... did it stop because of you?

AMBER
Nobody touched it.

Regan doesn't answer. The TV clicks back on by itself. This time- no video. Just sound. A low tone. Almost conversational. Regan winces.

BENJAMIN
(low, realizing)
It's not watching us.
(beat)
It's watching through you.

REGAN
Oh HELL NO. I didn't ask for this!
I don't hear things.

Benjamin and Amber step toward Regan.

AMBER
You didn't before.

REGAN
What? Why me?? I don't understand.
Turn this shit off!

She steps forward again. The TV shrieks. The speakers distort. The image bends inward. Regan reaches for the TV.

AMBER
Regan--don't--

The moment she touches the TV, a searing flash. A burn tears across her palm.

REGAN
AH! It burned me!

AMBER
You're bleeding--oh my God--here--

Amber grabs a strip of cloth from her sleeve and wraps Regan's hand.

Benjamin doesn't move. He's staring at the TV. The screen stabilizes and the image shifts on its own Not Benjamin's apartment, back to Regan's hospital room.

BENJAMIN (LOW)
It's not reacting to the machine.
(beat)
It's reacting to you.

REGAN
Don't say that.

Regan winces.

REGAN (CONT'D)
It's louder when I'm close.

Benjamin turns--

He sees something that stops him cold.

Another version of himself walking calmly past the archway.
Same clothes.

BENJAMIN
... What the hell?

CARMILLA
Ben?

BENJAMIN
I just watched myself leave.

HAROLD
You're seeing it now. The closer
we get, the more time folds.

Without warning, Lucy appears in the far corner. No one saw her arrive.

She tilts her head, face calm but it glitches, her eyes stuttering side to side, her body strobing in and out of place.

REGAN
Lucy?

LUCY
The veil thins.

CARMILLA
How long have you been standing
there?

Lucy flickers and is gone. No one follows up.

BENJAMIN
We need to go. Now.

HAROLD
Time doesn't work right down here.
Move.

They run.

INT. STAIRWELL - MOMENTS LATER

Benjamin glances sideways.

Through a slit in the stairwell wall, he sees himself again
-- standing in the dark. Watching. Motionless.

Their eyes lock. Then he vanishes.

INT. UPPER HALLWAY - NIGHT

They step into a freshly cleaned hallway.

The floors gleam.

The walls are perfectly still.

It's quiet.

AMBER
Back to normal?

REGAN
Whatever that is.

HAROLD
All prisons feel clean before the
execution.

Everyone stands in silence.

Just breathing.

FADE OUT.

INT. ABANDONED WARD - NIGHT

Regan lies awake on a stripped hospital cot, eyes open,
staring at the ceiling. She has not moved in hours.

Amber sleeps on the floor in the corner, wrapped in a thin blanket. Her sleep is shallow. She shifts. Her hand twitches like she is reacting to something unseen.

Benjamin stands at the window. He watches the corridor beyond the glass. Shadows stretch and curl across the floor and walls. They move slowly, like fingers searching.

Amber opens her eyes. She watches Benjamin for a moment before speaking.

BENJAMIN
(glancing at Regan)
She didn't sleep at all.

Amber sits up, rubbing her face.

AMBER
Neither did you.

Regan exhales, frustrated.

REGAN
I can feel it now. All the time.
Like something's right under my
skin.

Benjamin turns from the window.

BENJAMIN
The room downstairs. Whatever that
was. It reacted when you were
close.

Regan sits up.

REGAN
I didn't do anything.

BENJAMIN
I know.

Amber reaches for a small cloth pouch beside her. The fabric is worn thin. She opens it and spills the contents onto the floor. Old tokens. Folded scraps of paper. Torn drawings. Repeated shapes.

She picks up an old iron key.

AMBER
This opens the ward past the south
staircase. No one goes there.

She looks between them.

 AMBER (CONT'D)
I think we should.

Benjamin studies the key, uneasy but nodding.

Regan hesitates, then swings her legs off the cot.

INT. SOUTH WING - LATER

The hallway is decayed.

Mold creeps up the walls. Paint peels in long strips. Doors are scratched and barely hanging on rusted hinges.

Cracked fluorescent lights buzz overhead. Some flicker. Some stay dark.

The sound follows them.

They stop at the final door.

It is intact.

Amber places her hand on it, then pulls back.

 AMBER
It's cold.

Amber inserts the key.

The lock resists, then clicks open.

INT. SEALED ROOM - CONTINUOUS

They step inside.

The room is arranged deliberately.

Candles burned down to wax stumps line the perimeter.

Mirrors are mounted along the walls, every one of them covered with black cloth.

In the center of the room sits a glass display case.

Inside it is a flat object.

Cracked. Worn. Marked with symbols that no one comments on.

A small marker rests near its center.

Regan stops short.

She stares at it longer than she means to.

REGAN
What is that.

Benjamin steps closer to the glass.

He squints.

BENJAMIN
I don't know.

Amber scans the room instead of the object.

AMBER
This feels like more storage. Not
a shrine.

Regan moves closer to the case.

REGAN
Then why seal it like this.

Amber reaches up and pulls the cloth from one of the
mirrors.

The reflection reveals Regan standing there.

Her reflection's mouth moves.

It speaks silently.

Regan freezes.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Do you see that.

Benjamin looks at the mirror.

BENJAMIN
No.

A sharp crack splits the air.

The glass display fractures slightly.

Inside, the marker shifts.

Not far. Just enough to be noticed.

The lights flicker.

The temperature drops fast.

Regan inhales sharply.

In the far corner of the room, Lucy stands.

She is already there.

LUCY
You're not supposed to stare at
it.

AMBER
How long have you been there.

Lucy smiles faintly. Not kind. Not cruel. She turns and walks into the dark. She disappears behind a shelf. Regan's voice tightens.

REGAN
Why does this keep reacting to me?

AMBER
I don't know why.

Benjamin looks back at the glass.

BENJAMIN
Don't touch it.

Regan steps forward anyway. Glass crunches under her shoes. She stops inches from the case.

REGAN
I'm not touching it.

The candles blow out. A cold air rushes through the room. The walls flicker. For a fraction of a second, the room drops out. Darkness. Regan gasps and stumbles back. The lights return.

Regan's eyes widen. Benjamin and Amber stare at her.

From the shadows:

BENJAMIN
Did you hear something?

REGAN
No.

The hum settles back in. Low. Constant. Uninterested.

FADE OUT.

INT. SEALED ROOM - CONTINUOUS

The room is darker than before. Shadows bend unnaturally across the walls. The candles are dead. Cold air hovers like fog.

Regan stands frozen, her hand still on the marker. No one speaks at first -- they all just breathe, watching the smoke-like tendrils swirl above the board encased in glass.

AMBER

There are rules... Ways people say you can destroy a Ouija board. We can destroy it. But we have to be careful.

BENJAMIN

What kind of rules?

AMBER

Break it into seven pieces. Burn it. Bury the ashes.

BENJAMIN

That's a lot of superstition. Do you actually believe that?

Amber pauses. She gestures around the room where obviously supernatural events take place.

AMBER

(Sarcastic)

..... yeah.

(beat)

I think this place pulled something out of it. And now... it can't get back in.

Benjamin frowns -- looking at the warped mirror cloths.

BENJAMIN

Out of where? The board?

Amber looks around the room slowly.

AMBER

The mirrors... covered in black. Like a wake. Old tradition -- you cover mirrors to stop spirits from finding their way back.

She walks to the nearest one, gripping the edge of the cloth.

CARMILLA
 Leave it wrapped up nice and
 tight. It bites when it sees the
 light.

Amber yanks it anyway.

Behind the cloth: a mirror, blackened at the edges, the
 glass warped like it caught fire from the inside.

AMBER
 Look at this. And...
 (leaning closer)
 The board.

They crowd around the glass case again. Beneath the marker
 lies a warped, aged board -- cracked down its center, split
 into jagged fragments. Ash dust clings to the display
 interior.

REGAN
 It's already been burned.

BENJAMIN
 But it wasn't buried.

CARMILLA
 So... what happens if we just
 leave it here? Let it rot and
 whisper to itself?

The board inside the case begins to tremble. A hum builds
 from the walls -- not mechanical, but alive, like breath
 behind drywall.

Suddenly--

The marker slams against the glass and jerks to a letter:

"B."
 Then again: "U." "R." "Y."

SPIRIT VOICE (V.O.)
 BURY. END. BURY.

REGAN
 It's trying to finish what someone
 else started.

HAROLD
 We shouldn't be hearing this.
 (beat, almost a whisper)
 (MORE)

HAROLD (CONT'D)
We're not supposed to be this
close to knowing.

The walls begin to pulse, slow and wet -- like lungs
expanding. The room fills with thick gray smoke. It doesn't
choke, but it clings. Feels aware.

BENJAMIN
We need to move. Now.

Amber yanks the glass lid off. Regan reaches down -- lifts
the board, her palm still bandaged and bloody. The board
smokes faintly, but she holds it firm.

REGAN
Where do we even take this? We
can't get outside. The windows
don't open. The exits--

AMBER
There's one place. (pulls
parchment from her pouch) There's
a section on the layout we haven't
been to. No label. Just a symbol.

She shows the crude map. One corner marked with an X inside
a circle.

BENJAMIN
Seriously? Did you build this
place? Why do you know all of
this?? Fuck it. Let's go.

AMBER
I pay attention.

He opens the door. Cold air rushes in like something
waiting.

Behind them, the board hisses softly. The marker twitches.

HAROLD
If it's wrong... If it's all part
of a game...

CARMILLA
Then we play it louder. Until the
walls remember the notes.

The group exits, the board in Regan's hands, the smoke
curling behind them, whispering like wind across a grave.

INT. DIM HALLWAY - NIGHT

The group hurries through the final unexplored corridor. The shadows don't move -- they watch.

A door at the end bears no label. Just a faint impression in the wood, like a hand print burned there long ago.

The walls drip with condensation. Every light they pass buzzes, then dies behind them.

At the end: a door with no label. No knob. Just a worn black cross.

Benjamin places his hand on it. It opens on its own.

INT. ABANDONED CHAPEL - CONTINUOUS

They step into a forgotten chapel space.

Pews overturned. Altar shattered. Moss creeps up cracked walls, curling toward burned prayer candles long cold.

But the space is still. Dry. The air doesn't hum here.

A strange peaceful unease fills the room.

AMBER

Maybe we shouldn't be doing this.

BENJAMIN

You said this was the last place on the map.

AMBER

Yeah, but that doesn't mean we're supposed to mess with it. Ouija boards are... They're doorways. Garbage disguised as toys. You don't just open a door and hope for the best.

REGAN

We didn't open it.

AMBER

No, but someone did. And every time we touch it, we feed it.

(beat)

I wish we'd never started this. I wish we'd just left it in the dirt where it belongs.

She steps back, visibly shaken. Her hands tremble. Carmilla gently touches her arm.

CARMILLA
But we didn't close the door, did we? So now something's coming through.

AMBER (SOFTLY)
I've read stories. People disappearing. People going mad. It doesn't just let go.

BENJAMIN
Then help us end it.

Amber takes a breath, steadies herself. She kneels where the altar once stood, the stone cracked and blackened.

AMBER
Right here. If anything's sacred in here... it's this.

Regan steps forward and places the board on the ground.

It immediately pulses with heat -- faint smoke rising from its edges.

BENJAMIN
Let's bury it. Now.

They begin to break the chapel floor, stone by brittle stone.

BENJAMIN pauses, squinting at something under the cracked slab. In a flash hallucination -- he sees a hand buried in the soil, reaching up, its fingers twitching before dissolving into dust.

He says nothing. Keeps digging.

Beneath: soil. Real, untouched earth.

REGAN
How is this here?

HAROLD
Like it always was. Even before the building.

They dig deeper, until the hole is wide enough.

Regan picks up the board with both hands.

The marker spins violently, then flies off, slamming into the nearest wall and cracking.

The board screeches softly -- a sound like wind through teeth.

AMBER (WARNING)
Whatever happens next... don't
speak to it again.

REGAN
Oh, I won't.

She lowers the board in.

It shakes. Then settles.

They begin covering it with soil.

As the dirt touches the surface, the lights in the chapel
dim -- not flicker, but fade, like something dying quietly.

CARMILLA
Do you feel that?

HAROLD
Less... noise.

AMBER
It's like... something stopped.

They pat the dirt down with their hands. Benjamin looks up
-- and for the first time since waking here, the silence
feels real.

Then: a soft creak from behind them.

They all turn.

Lucy stands in the chapel doorway.

Head tilted. Barefoot.

LUCY
You buried it?

BENJAMIN
Yes.

Lucy walks forward. Her footsteps make no sound.

She stands over the fresh soil.

LUCY
Sometimes... things grow back.

She smiles. Not unkindly. Then walks out without another
word.

Nobody questions it.

REGAN

What now?

BENJAMIN
We see if anything changes.

They remain still for a moment.

Nothing stirs. No voices. No glitches. Just... quiet.

FADE OUT.

INT. ABANDONED CHAPEL - LATER

Regan stands over the place where the board is buried, hands trembling, her bandage soaked through.

Benjamin crouches beside the hole, packing down damp earth, his fingers numb from cold.

Amber paces anxiously, her boots clicking across broken stone.

Suddenly--Candles relight. One by one.

A ring of flame builds around the chapel's perimeter -- flickering, coordinated, sentient.

AMBER (WHISPERS)
It knows.

The walls tremble. Not violently -- rhythmically, like a heartbeat.

The soil shifts -- heaving, resisting.

BENJAMIN
Hold it down!

He presses both hands into the dirt. It's like pressing against muscle -- the board thrums beneath.

REGAN drops to her knees and shoves with him, their arms shaking with effort.

CARMILLA (O.S.)
It's trying to climb back out!

AMBER
You have to say it!

REGAN
Say what?

AMBER
Goodbye. That's the final rule.
You have to close the circle!

Regan takes a breath.

The air turns thick and soupy -- her voice struggles to rise above it.

REGAN
You told me not to speak to it!!

AMBER
SAY GOOD BYE!!

REGAN (YELLING)
GOODBYE!!!

A beat.

Nothing.

Then --

CRACK!

A thunderous snap from above -- like the ceiling breaking in half.

All the candles blow out at once.

Darkness. The board stops moving. The soil flattens. The room exhales. The hum... disappears.

Just silence.

They stare. Listen. The silence feels genuine -- not imposed.

BENJAMIN (SOFTLY)
Did it work?

AMBER
I don't know. But if we stay here... It might not matter.

INT. HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER

The corridor seems... normal.

Clean. Still. Smells faintly of disinfectant and lemon polish -- too clean, like a reset button was pressed.

REGAN
It feels lighter.

They walk slowly, eyes wide. As they near the common room, they see Otto, standing at the far end of the hallway.

Unmoving. Silent.

His eyes are glassy, unreadable.

OTTO
Where did you go?

BENJAMIN
We buried it. We finished it.

Otto doesn't respond. He just stares past them.

OTTO (QUIETLY)
No one ever really finishes it.

He turns. Begins walking down a side corridor. Flickers once. Then vanishes behind a wall that wasn't there a moment ago.

The group stands frozen, unsure what just passed.

FADE OUT.

INT. COMMON ROOM - NIGHT

The room feels untouched, frozen in time. A radio plays faint static in the background. Benjamin, Regan, and Amber enter slowly.

Then -- a bloodcurdling scream. Malachai sits on the floor, arms wrapped around himself, staring blankly ahead.

MALACHAI
I didn't do it. He just climbed
inside me.

The room lights flicker. An orderly appears and places a hand on his shoulder.

MALACHAI (CONT'D)
Is it my turn?? Does my mom miss
me?

Malachai doesn't resist. He's taken away --but looks directly at Benjamin as he's led off.

Otto sits at the window, back turned.

REGAN
He's been off since we got back.

AMBER
He was always strange. But now
he's... Quiet.

BENJAMIN
Quiet Otto is terrifying.

They watch as Otto hums to himself, fingers twitching rhythmically on the arm of his chair. He mutters under his breath --barely audible.

OTTO
Circles... ash... open-and-shut...
burn the name... never the bone...

REGAN
That doesn't sound like him.

AMBER
No. It doesn't.

Amber edges forward, cautiously.

AMBER (CONT'D)
Otto? Are you feeling okay?

He stops humming. Slowly turns. His eyes are darker--almost sunken. His mouth twists into a grin that doesn't reach his eyes.

OTTO
You thought it would end. When you
buried it. Silly girl.

REGAN
What did you say?

OTTO (SUDDENLY LOUDER)
You buried wood. Not intention.

The lights flicker. The radio hisses, then reverses itself, spitting out garbled words backward.

BENJAMIN
Something followed us out. Or
someone invited it.

Otto rises slowly, his bones cracking, but his body doesn't react to the pain. It's too fluid. Almost borrowed.

OTTO
There must always be a host.

He turns and walks out of the room without another word.

AMBER
Oh no. Oh no no no...

REGAN
He's possessed. Isn't he?

BENJAMIN
Or worse--maybe he always was.

INT. COMMON ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The group stands in stunned silence. Amber checks the hallway, but Otto is gone.

Suddenly, from behind the couch--JACE emerges, arms crossed.

JACE
You buried something you didn't understand, didn't you?

They all jump.

AMBER
Where the hell have you been?

JACE (DRYLY)
Avoiding this circus.

BENJAMIN
We thought you were gone.

JACE
I tried. Hallway looped three times, then I ended up in the kitchen.
(beat)
Only the coffee was missing. Explain that. How the fuck do I survive this place without coffee?

He steps forward, eyes scanning them. He stops on Regan.

JACE (CONT'D)
You're bleeding again.

Regan looks down -- her bandage is fresh, but a line of blood trails down her wrist.

REGAN
I didn't feel anything.

JACE
That's the problem. You're numb.

BENJAMIN
We need to stick together.
Otto's--

JACE
(INTERRUPTING)
Unstable! No kidding. He's been
whispering to the air since I got
here.

AMBER
Do you think it's the board? Still
active?

JACE
I think you buried a matchstick in
a bonfire.

He walks to the window Otto had been sitting at and looks
out.

JACE (CONT'D)
There's something in the
courtyard.

They all gather behind him.

Outside: no one. Just flickering shadows.

Then--Otto's silhouette passes by. He's walking into the
east wing. Alone.

BENJAMIN
We have to follow him.

JACE
Hell no. I ain't doing a damn
thing. All I am doing is my time
until I can leave this place.

They exchange glances. No one speaks.

FADE OUT.

INT. SOUTHEAST WING - NIGHT

An alarm pulses faintly in the background, like a heartbeat
on life support. The hallway is choked in red emergency
light, casting long, fractured shadows along the decaying
walls.

Regan, Benjamin, and Amber move fast, flinching at every
echoing groan.

AMBER
Maybe he is a vessel.

REGAN
A what?

AMBER
The thing in the board--maybe it's
using him to anchor itself here.

BENJAMIN
So if we stop Otto-- I mean, help
Otto....

REGAN
We might stop it.

INT. TREATMENT ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The door creaks open -- metal scraping against metal. Inside, a rotted therapy room, and at its center: Otto, crouched on all fours, drawing a massive sigil with trembling, blood-soaked hands. The symbol pulses, wet and breathing.

His head jerks unnaturally as they enter -- as if strings were yanked.

OTTO
You shouldn't be here.

His voice is hollow. Somewhere between a whisper and a growl.

REGAN
Otto--fight it. Whatever's inside
you--

OTTO (SHAKING)
There's no Otto. Just... the
vessel.

AMBER
This is wrong. This is so wrong.

Otto's back arches sharply, bones cracking. His eyes roll back. A black mist begins curling out of his mouth, coiling above him like smoke forming a shape.

BENJAMIN
Oh God.

Otto screams -- but the scream is layered -- both human and something inhuman beneath.

The lights explode, glass raining down.

The sigil glows red-hot -- the floor around it burns in a perfect ring.

Otto's body levitates, limbs trembling, head lolled back.

From his chest, the black mist grows into a snaking tendril-- reaching for the ceiling, searching.

REGAN (SCREAMING)

NO!

She rushes forward and grabs a nearby metal lamp, smashing it directly into the center of the sigil.

The mist SHRIEKS. The circle spasms with electricity.

Otto speaks again -- voice now fractured, glitching.

OTTO (SHIFTED, OVERLAPPED)

Some must stay. Some must hold.
Some must--

AMBER

Nobody's staying. You don't get to
decide that!

Amber reaches into her pouch and pulls out the last relic -- a shard of burned summoning glass from the chamber.

AMBER (CONT'D)

Benjamin--help me. Now!

They drop to their knees and begin etching a new circle around Otto using the shard, dragging it through the tile. The sound is like nails across bone.

Otto begins convulsing midair, blood trailing from his nose and ears. The black mist thrashes violently.

REGAN (TEARS IN HER VOICE)

Otto--if you're still in there--
please...

The mist turns toward Regan, the shape nearly humanoid now -- thin, tall, crawling with faces.

Amber slams the shard into the ground to complete the circle.

A BLINDING FLASH--

The mist shrieks, recoils, and slams into the floor, disappearing in a blast of wind and smoke that blows out the remaining bulbs and knocks them all backward.

SILENCE.

For a moment, nothing moves.

Then Otto collapses, slamming to the floor with a dull thud.

He gasps--coughing, blinking like someone pulled from drowning.

OTTO (HOARSE, HUMAN)
What... happened?

REGAN
You're okay. You're okay.

He starts to cry--silent, uncontrollable sobs.

Amber wraps her arms around him. Benjamin sits back, shaking, his hands covered in ash and blood.

FADE OUT.

INT. TREATMENT ROOM - LATER

The sigil is now a charcoal scar baked into the tile. A single overhead fixture flickers, struggling to stay lit. Otto lies on a wheeled cot, wrapped in a blanket, murmuring half-dream words.

BENJAMIN
Is it over?

AMBER
For now... but we don't know
what's still inside him.

The door creaks open.

ANNA steps in. She's perfectly composed, but something is... off:

Her voice is a shade higher, almost sing-song-y.

A jelly bracelet peeks from under her starched cuff.

Her earrings are tiny plastic stars that don't match her usual minimalist style.

She shuts the door and faces them with a smile that's a fraction too wide.

ANNA
Hello! There you are. I've been
looking everywhere, guys.

The casual "guys" lands strangely in the quiet room.

REGAN
Doctor, Otto was--
(glances at Otto)
--floating. Something took him
over.

ANNA
Otto's always been a bit
theatrical. Creative minds need...
boundaries.

BENJAMIN
We all saw it. That wasn't
theater.

Anna strolls to the ruined symbol, crouches. She traces an edge with one gloved fingertip, like a teenager testing wet paint.

ANNA
Hmm... spooky.
(turns to them)
You've made such a mess. I'll have
to, y'know, fix this.

She gives a half-shrug that looks more high-school hallway than clinical authority.

AMBER
You know that isn't some art
project.

Anna's smile flickers--just a second--then resets.

ANNA
Maybe some things don't need
explaining. Stories can get... out
of hand.

She rises, dusting imaginary dirt off her coat. Under the fluorescents the jelly bracelet seems to glow.

REGAN
Doctor--are you all right?

Anna pauses, humming a tune under her breath--an old 1990s lullaby that definitely does not fit the sterile room. She

catches herself, clears her throat.

ANNA
Everyone needs rest. Especially
Otto.
(cheerfully)
(MORE)

ANNA (CONT'D)
Please find some peace and quiet,
'kay?

The little "'kay?" slips out before she can smooth it over. Her cheeks color--tiny, startled embarrassment--then she's professional again.

BENJAMIN
That didn't feel like a story.

Anna's eyes flick to Benjamin--an odd mix of adult patience and teenage challenge --then she heads to the door. Just before exiting, she murmurs almost to herself:

ANNA
Mom's gonna--
(catch)
I mean--this is not good.

She exits, humming the lullaby. Door clicks shut.

AFTERMATH

The four stare at the door.

REGAN
Did she just say Mom? I don't like
that she didn't say goodbye.
(scowls)

AMBER
And... "'kay." She never talks
like that.

From the cot, Otto mumbles a lucid fragment:

OTTO
Girl at the board... hands like
glass...

He drifts back into uneasy sleep.

JACE appears in the doorway, arms folded.

JACE
Our friendly shrink just called us
guys. I'd call that a red flag.

BENJAMIN
Or a glitch. Like everything else.

They all look down at the smoking sigil, then at Otto.

The fixture above them finally dies, plunging the room into darkness lit only by hallway glow. No one moves.

FADE OUT.

INT. GROUP THERAPY ROOM - NEXT MORNING

Morning light barely pierces the grime-streaked windows, casting long, fractured shadows across a circle of mismatched chairs.

The air is stale, like it hasn't moved in weeks.

ANNA stands at the front, clutching a clipboard too tightly. Her smile is pasted on--cheerful but brittle.

ANNA
Hello, everyone. I'm so glad you
all made it today. I just love
when we're all together.
(beat)
Let's take a moment to share how
we're feeling, one at a time.
Okay?

Her voice lands wrong. Too light. Too practiced. Like she's performing.

Amber shifts in her seat. Regan glares. Benjamin doesn't move.

ANNA (CONT'D)
Otto? You had a hard day
yesterday. Want to start us off?

OTTO
(voice distant)
There was... something. Not just a
voice. Something else. Something
in me.

Anna smiles too wide. Her pen trembles over the clipboard.

ANNA
That's... wonderful insight.
(chirpy)
But how could that even be?

BENJAMIN
Because it was. And you know it
was. Don't patronize us.

REGAN
It wasn't psychosis. We saw it. We
all saw it.

AMBER
And if you say it's just our minds
again, I swear--

ANNA
Let's not get hostile. The energy
in the room is... shifting.

POP.

A fluorescent bulb explodes overhead, raining sparks. No
one flinches.

REGAN
That's the third one this week.

AMBER
Look.

She points to the back wall. The paint ripples--breathing.

BENJAMIN
It's breaking down. The illusion.
The drugs. Something's failing.

Anna edges backward, her posture less doctor, more relaxed.

ANNA
Maybe its time for... for some
quiet reflection.

OTTO (STANDING SHARPLY)
She doesn't see it. She can't see
it.

REGAN (SNAPPING)
YES SHE CAN!

Everyone jumps. Regan's face is red, fists clenched.

REGAN (CONT'D)
You're not some clueless
counselor! You know what's
happening--you've always known.
Why else would you keep us here?

Anna freezes mid-step, eyes wide, mouth slightly open.

ANNA (SOFTLY)
 I... I didn't mean...please calm
 down. It spins in here when you
 get angry.

REGAN
 (mean, desperate)
 What are you? A prison guard? A
 puppet?

REGAN (CONT'D)
 Or just some scared little girl in
 a lab coat playing make-believe?

ANNA
 (quiet, almost childish)
 That's not fair...

REGAN
 No. What's not fair is lying to us
 while people vanish. While we
 drown in this place.

OTTO
 Something's coming again.

From below--a metallic moan, like the bowels of the
 building groaning. Then: bells. Deep, melodic... but
 distant.

No bells exist in this hospital.

CARMILLA (WHISPERS AND DANCES)
 Do you hear that?

HAROLD steps into the room from the hall, wild-eyed.

HAROLD
 It's starting again. Just like the
 night Lucy glitched.

The group instinctively forms a tight inner circle.

Anna hugs the clipboard to her chest like a schoolbook,
 fingers trembling.

ANNA
 Everyone just... calm down.

JACE (O.S.)
 She's not gonna help. She's as
 stuck as we are.

He leans in the doorway, silent until now.

JACE (CONT'D)
But I'd like to know who's pulling
her strings.

Anna's mouth opens--no sound comes out.

BENJAMIN
You want us quiet because we're
getting close.

Walls begin to swell again, expanding and contracting--
inhaling.

OTTO (MURMURING)
The board never left. It just
turned this place inside out.

REGAN (TO ANNA)
If you want to help us--prove it.
Or stay out of our way.

Anna stares at her. Her eyes flicker--not blinking,
flicker, like static.

Then she turns and walks out without another word.

BENJAMIN
Where is she going? She didn't say
goodbye. Again! Why is she being
so rude now? I thought words
mattered!

HAROLD (GRAVELY)
Probably where all the other ones
go... before they disappear.

FADE OUT.

INT. ACTIVITY ROOM - NIGHT

The patients sit quietly around a long, sterile table. The
lights above flicker at regular intervals. Otto keeps to
himself, eyes never lifting. Regan eats slowly. Amber picks
at her tray. Benjamin stares across the room.

Malachai hides under a table. Eyes glowing faintly.

BENJAMIN
I thought you left.

MALACHAI
I never leave.

Malachai scratches at the floor and eventually curls into a fetal position and cries.

The room is dim except for a small desk lamp on a table. Near the end of the table sits HAROLD. He hums softly to himself. He is usually folding napkins into tiny shapes--birds, flowers, and stars. Tonight Harold sits alone, working on a puzzle.

Tonight, he hums louder.

A kitten puzzle. Only a few pieces left. He hums a tune, low and off-key -- something sweet and old-fashioned.

BENJAMIN (O.S.)
You're still at that thing?

HAROLD (SMILING)
I'm almost done. Gotta finish it before we all go batty. There we go. Beautiful.

REGAN
Harold, we need you in the rec room. Jace found something behind the vending machines.

HAROLD
Always something, huh?

He places the final piece, then pauses. His hands rest on the table. He leans back and closes his eyes. A long, peaceful breath and begins folding a napkin into a bird.

Then--his eyes snap open. Something's shifted. The clock on the wall rewinds. The lamp flickers. He hears soft footsteps -- even though no one is behind him.

Harold stands. Slowly. Looks around. From the hallway, a soft humming -- familiar. The same tune he was humming.

HAROLD (CONT'D)
No... no, please.

HAROLD (CONT'D)
Can I just... sit for a few more minutes?

INT. ACTIVITY ROOM - SAME TIME

REGAN
Harold's louder than usual.

AMBER
I don't think he's humming. I
think he's chanting.

Benjamin looks closer. Harold's hands tremble.

BENJAMIN
Harold?

HAROLD
I made it. I made it to the door.
It's opening now. I'm going home.

AMBER
What? They are letting you go?
How??

Suddenly, Harold drops the napkin he was holding. It
flutters to the floor. He looks up at them-- serene.

HAROLD
My wife.

REGAN
Harold, what are you talking
about? Are you OK??

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Harold stumbles into the hallway. Empty. The lights buzz
overhead.

From the far end, two orderlies appear. No faces, no
voices. Just shadows in uniform.

HAROLD (CHOKING BACK TEARS)
Wait... wait! I remember now.

He presses himself against the wall as they move closer.
Something in him... shifts.

He clutches his chest.

HAROLD (CONT'D)
I wasn't always old. I had a wife.
Her name was June. She wore lemon
perfume.
(sobbing now)
She used to hum that song while
painting in the kitchen. I'd
forgotten. I'd forgotten her.

The orderlies stop just feet away.

HAROLD (CONT'D)
I don't want to forget again.

Please... I don't want to forget
her face.

The hallway light above him goes out. Everything is silent except the hum.

HAROLD (CONT'D)
Tell them I loved them. Tell them
I remembered.

He takes a step forward, shoulders straight, tears falling freely.

The orderlies guide Harold down the hall.

INT. ACTIVITY ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The table is empty. The puzzle complete.

In Harold's chair: a lemon-colored thread.

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

They run into the hall. No one.

Just the sound of the wind, and the clock ticking forward again.

REGAN (BARELY AUDIBLE)
No...

AMBER
Where is he? Did they release
him?? We didn't even get to say
goodbye.

They stand in silence. The moment stretches.

Then, faintly -- as if from behind the walls -- they hear humming.

The same tune Harold sang. They listen. And they cry. Malachai screams from the other room.

FADE OUT.

INT. WEST WING - NIGHT

Thunder rolls low in the distance as the group gathers in the west wing--a part of the hospital no one ever uses.

The hallway seems longer than usual, the lights too dim, as if something unseen leaches energy from the walls. The wallpaper bubbles like it's exhaling.

REGAN
Where's Amber?

BENJAMIN

She said she was going to check on you, Otto. But that was an hour ago. She wouldn't leave. She couldn't get far. Not without telling someone.

They walk slowly, past peeling wallpaper and rusted equipment. A broken intercom hisses static, then cuts out.

Then--a soft, rhythmic clicking. They follow it down the corridor until they reach a heavy metal door marked "ARCHIVES." It groans open.

INT. ARCHIVES ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Colder. Stiller. Dust clings in thick layers, stirred by their breath.

File cabinets stretch deep into the shadows like tombstones.

In the center of the room--Amber's journal, alone on the floor. Open to a blank page.

REGAN

Amber?

BENJAMIN

Where is she?

OTTO

She was afraid of this place. Said it watched her. Maybe... maybe it took her.

REGAN

Don't say that! And what do you mean it?

OTTO

I mean whatever is behind this whole... illusion. The hospital, the rooms--it's changing. It's not holding together anymore.

REGAN

No. She's still here. She has to be.

CARMILLA

(checking the corners)

What if she's just somewhere we can't see?

JACE

Or somewhere we're not supposed
to.

Benjamin kneels and picks up the journal.

The pages begin to flip on their own, as if something searches through them. Faster. Faster--then it stops dead on a single page.

A symbol is scrawled in thick, black ink. Jagged, haphazard. Not written--carved.

REGAN

What is it?

BENJAMIN

Same one from the circle Otto drew.

The floor rumbles. A low, subsonic tremor. Lights flicker violently.

From deep in the shadows--a whisper.

AMBER (O.S.)

Don't trust the walls...

They turn. Nothing. Just a filing cabinet drawer, slowly sliding open on its own.

OTTO

She's... trapped in the layers of this place.

REGAN

We're all trapped in this place.

OTTO

No. Not like that.

BENJAMIN

Before she disappeared, she was asking questions about Anna. Said something felt wrong about her.

REGAN

You mean besides her talking like she's reading from a script?

OTTO

Or how she always smells like burning incense. Think she's afraid she's gonna catch the crazy?

CARMILLA

Her office floats. It's here, but it isn't. Like a dream pretending to be a room.

They all stare blankly at Carmilla.

Beat.

BENJAMIN
The candles. Crystals. Mood
lighting. Like a Pinterest board
for witchcraft exploded. You think
she is a witch?

REGAN
Always lamps. Never ceiling
lights.

OTTO
Maybe she is as afraid of this
place as we are. Maybe it's
protection spells.

They pause. The tremor stops. Everything is too quiet now.

BENJAMIN
Amber said Anna was pretending.
Like a kid playing dress-up.

REGAN
SHE DOES sound rehearsed.

CARMILLA
Like she's trying to remember
lines. Not... feel them. Like
being told what to say.

They mostly ignore Carmilla now, even though if they
listen, she makes the most sense.

OTTO
It's almost ritualistic.

INT. HALLWAY OUTSIDE DR. ANNA'S OFFICE - NIGHT

They approach the heavy wooden door. Ornate. Out of place
in the hospital's sterile architecture.

Benjamin leans in, ear against it.

BENJAMIN
She's in there. I smell incense.

OTTO
And I hear... music?

CARMILLA
It's too new. Too loud. Like
laughing at a funeral.

Carmilla mutter this under her breath with a smile that
doesn't reach her eyes.

Inside, faint pop music plays. Then laughter--Anna's voice, light, joking with someone.

REGAN
She's not alone. Who is she
talking to?

Benjamin jiggles the handle. Locked. Otto slams his shoulder into it. Nothing.

Regan notices the flicker of warm light under the door.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Everything else is falling
apart... and this door is solid?

JACE
Maybe it's protected.
(almost sarcastically)
Or dead-bolted.
(matter of fact)

BENJAMIN
She is hiding something.

OTTO
Or holding something in.

They pound on the door.

BENJAMIN
Anna! Open up!

The music cuts. The laughter stops. Just silence now. And that sickly-sweet smell of candles.

A whisper seeps through the door.

ANNA (O.S.)
I didn't mean to break it...

REGAN (QUIET, TO HERSELF)
Break what?

CARMILLA
Did she just confess?

Suddenly, the light under the door disappears. The scent fades.

Nothing but heartbeat silence.

The group stands still.

JACE
I think we just asked the right
question. She's slipping.

FADE OUT.

INT. EMPTY COMMON ROOM - LATER

The group sits in the dim light of the common room. A small lamp flickers softly. Outside, wind rattles the windows.

Benjamin stares into space. Regan paces near the window. Otto taps his fingers, rhythmic and uneven. Carmilla clutches Amber's journal to her chest.

BENJAMIN
Maybe... maybe we're overreacting.

REGAN
(over her shoulder)
Overreacting?

BENJAMIN
Look, Anna's a doctor. She's allowed a private life. Maybe she talks differently when she's not treating us. Everyone wears a mask at work.

OTTO
So incense and candlelight and whispering Latin is her me time?

REGAN
She wasn't alone in there. She was laughing like she hadn't a care in the world. It didn't sound like her... or maybe it did. The real her.

BENJAMIN
Maybe she is strange, but that doesn't make her evil. We're residents of this place, right?

REGAN
Don't do that, Benjamin. Don't rationalize what you know feels wrong. She wasn't chatting. She was behaving like someone else.
(pause)
Amber knew it. That's why she started watching her.

OTTO
And now Amber's gone. What does
that tell you?

Silence. Regan stops pacing. Carmilla sets the journal on
the table.

CARMILLA
She didn't scream. Didn't vanish
in front of us. Just... faded.
Like her thread was clipped.

REGAN
She was looking for truth. Maybe
she found it.

BENJAMIN
(gritting his teeth)
I should have stopped her.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
She was unraveling and I... I let
her go alone.

CARMILLA
She left her writings.

She opens the journal. A loose note tucked inside flutters
free. Benjamin catches it.

CLOSE-UP - the note reads:

"She watches everything. But she can't see herself. Look at
the mirror. The real one."

OTTO
The mirror...

BENJAMIN
The one in Anna's office?

REGAN
We never looked. We've been
staring at her... not what's
behind her.

CARMILLA
That mirror doesn't reflect us. It
reflects her. Who she really is.

A long beat. The wind outside builds. A door upstairs
creaks, slow and deliberate.

OTTO
And if we look in it?

REGAN

Then maybe we finally see where we really are.

BENJAMIN

Amber was right. Anna's not just hiding something.

(beat)

She might be the only one holding the door shut. Or the only one who can open it.

OTTO

Either way... we're not getting out unless we face her.

Another long silence. Somewhere deep in the hospital, a child's giggle echoes faintly, then vanishes.

REGAN

We stop pretending this is a hospital. This is a trap. And we either die here... Or we break free.

FADE OUT.

INT. STAIRWELL - NIGHT

The group stands at the bottom of the main stairwell. Above them, the slow, heavy creaking continues--wood groaning, something pacing.

Regan clutches the railing tightly.

REGAN

That's right above us.

OTTO

Could be the old infirmary. No one's used that wing in decades.

BENJAMIN

THEN WHY IS SOMEONE WALKING AROUND UP THERE?

A moment of silence. They all hear it: the deliberate pace of feet dragging just above them.

Then--it stops.

They exchange a look, then begin climbing. Each step is tense.

The creaking ceases as they reach the landing.

INT. UPPER FLOOR HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Dust coats the floor like snow. The air smells stale, metallic. The walls feel narrower than usual--as though the hallway is gently closing in.

CARMILLA
It's... small here.

REGAN
Feels like a pressure change. Like altitude.

They glance at each other. For a flash--Carmilla sees Benjamin blink, and for half a second, he's covered in burn scars. She flinches.

CARMILLA
Benjamin--your face--

BENJAMIN
What?

She stares. The scars are gone.

CARMILLA
I saw the fire lick your skin.

She caresses his face with concern.

The hallway is lined with sealed rooms. All locked. Except one.

A single door--slightly ajar. A warm, pulsing glow seeps through the gap.

INT. INFIRMARY - CONTINUOUS

Inside: abandoned beds, rusted IV stands, broken monitors. Glass shards glitter in the moonlight.

At the far end of the room--a figure stands motionless. Too still. Too dark.

Its eyes pitch black, its skin stretched thin. And then it tilts its head.

REGAN (SHARP WHISPER)
Is that... Anna?

BENJAMIN
No.

It steps forward. The voice that escapes its mouth is Anna's-- distorted and echoing.

ANNA-LIKE ENTITY
You shouldn't be here.

The voice overlaps with itself, like two recordings playing slightly out of sync. The air warps, and Benjamin's hand begins to tremble.

OTTO
It's using her voice.

BENJAMIN
It's not just that. It's not even solid. Look.

The figure flickers, momentarily revealing multiple versions of itself--Anna... a young girl... a writhing shadow... and then back.

The walls breathe, a low inhale-exhale rhythm, slow and pulsing. Regan grips a bedpost to steady herself.

Then-- The entity lunges forward.

It stops abruptly, as though caught by an invisible wire. It lets out a non-human screech, not in pain--but rage.

The floor trembles. The temperature drops.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
BACK OUT! NOW!

They stumble out, slamming the door behind them.

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

They stand in the silence.

Except... they're not standing together anymore.

Regan is suddenly alone--no one around her. She turns in panic. The hallway stretches endlessly in both directions.

REGAN
Hello?? Benjamin?! Otto?!

From the shadows--a voice answers in her own voice.

REGAN 2 (O.S.)
They're gone. And so are you.

She turns--and sees herself. Pale, blank-eyed, standing still just a few feet away.

Then--blink--and it's Benjamin in front of her again.

BENJAMIN
Regan?! What happened?

REGAN
I don't know. I saw... me.

BENJAMIN
We have to get out of this hallway.

CARMILLA
The mirror...

They all turn.

Carmilla stares into a dusty mirror on the infirmary door--only it's not reflecting the hallway.

It shows all of them standing in different places, facing away from each other.

And then: Amber appears in the reflection. Standing behind them.

But when they turn--she's not there.

OTTO (WHISPERS)
She's still here... somewhere.

Suddenly-- the mirror shatters. Loud, unnatural. No object touched it.

The creaking resumes--but now it's directly beneath them.

REGAN
We need to move.

FADE OUT.

INT. HALLWAY OUTSIDE ANNA'S OFFICE - DAY

A sickly yellow light filters through the high windows. Benjamin, Regan, and Otto stand again outside Anna's office. This time, there is no laughter. Just silence.

The yellow glow filters through the windows, casting long, warped shadows across the floor.

BENJAMIN
We've been chasing symbols.
Voices. Vanishing people. What if
we are circling the wrong truth?

REGAN
What truth is there in a place
like this?

BENJAMIN
None of this is psychological. Not
in the way she keeps telling us.

OTTO
Made to look like a hospital to
keep us docile. To keep us
guessing.

BENJAMIN
This place isn't a hospital. It's
a holding ground, a feeding
ground.

They glance back at Anna's door.

REGAN
Then who is she really?

BENJAMIN
Whoever--or whatever--she is,
she's keeping us in line.

OTTO
Then maybe it's time we stop being
polite about it.

They notice a faint glow beneath the door. This time, it
pulses with red instead of warm candlelight. As if it is
reacting.

REGAN
That thing in the infirmary. I saw
something there in its eyes. It
knew us.

They turn and walk away from Anna's office--more determined
than ever. The red under the door intensifies.

INT. DINING HALL - LATER

The light outside is oddly gray, giving the room a
washed-out hue.

Benjamin, Regan, and Otto sit at their usual table. Trays of untouched food sit before them, mold blooming along the edges like time has warped again. Everything feels off-kilter.

Patients dot the room like statues.

A few other patients scatter the large hall, but they're far apart and eerily silent.

One rocks slowly, humming a nursery rhyme. - Another whispers to the wall, weeping and giggling between breaths. - A third stares blankly at a wall where there's no window, mouthing silent words.

A man closer to the window cries softly, hands over his face. Their presence feels ghost like--there, yet unreachable.

At the far end, someone laughs into their empty hands.

REGAN

Has anyone else noticed we haven't seen an orderly in... Days?

OTTO

Gone. No shifts. Not even for meds. Not that they ever did much.

BENJAMIN

Just her. Always her.

They sit in silence for a moment, the weight of the observation hanging heavy in the air. The soft weeping nearby seems to grow louder.

They glance across the hall. A patient slams their head gently against the table in rhythm with the ticking of a broken clock.

REGAN

We used to hear them walking the halls. Buzzers. Carts. That white noise. Now it's just... absence.

OTTO

Shouldn't there be nurses? Schedules? More staff?

BENJAMIN

I thought that was just maybe budget cuts. But this?

REGAN

"Budget cuts." Yeah. OK.

Silence.

In the far corner, a music box begins playing by itself. Its warped melody echoes across the tile.

REGAN (CONT'D)
We need a plan.

OTTO
So we do what? Break in again? Confront her? Or we catch her off guard. She slips when things go off-script.... I'm in.

BENJAMIN
Yes, confront her. This whole place revolves around her. The locked door. The symbols. The vanishing people. She's at the center. She's not improvising anymore. She's reacting. Which means... she's afraid.

REGAN
We'll wait until tonight. When it's quiet. One of us distracts her. The other two gets in. Let's make her afraid again.

OTTO
Assuming she can be distracted.

BENJAMIN
She has a weakness. She acts like she's in control, but every time something breaks the pattern--she stumbles.

REGAN
So let's break the pattern.

They nod. A pact sealed in silence.

The camera pans wide. The other scattered patients continue in their cycles--rocking, crying, whispering. No one acknowledges them. The sound of a distant music box plays from somewhere unseen.

CLOSE-UP: a patient in the background begins laughing and crying at once, eyes darting back and forth like they're watching something crawl across the ceiling.

INT. VARIOUS LOCATIONS - LATER THAT NIGHT

The hospital begins to falter. Lights flicker wildly. Walls pulse like breathing skin.

The floors groan under invisible pressure. Benjamin, Regan, and Otto walk cautiously through the hallway, their eyes scanning everything.

A loud bang echoes from down a corridor.

REGAN
Did you hear that?

OTTO
Something's not right. It's
glitching again. Or unraveling.

Down the hall, they spot a patient running silently, mouth open in a scream--no sound. Hands scrape invisible walls. Then the patient freezes, flickers like bad reception, and disappears.

BENJAMIN
The others. They're not
hallucinating anymore. They're
seeing the same layers we are.

They reach a corridor lined with old hospital beds--stacked, rusted, forgotten. One shifts on its own.

From a room, sobbing erupts, then erupts into manic laughter.

They pass another room and see someone levitating, limbs bent backward, suspended midair. A blink--and it's empty again.

CARMILLA (O.S.)
(backing in to view, shaking)
Something touched me. But it
wasn't... here.

REGAN
Are we next?

OTTO
It's like... Something's testing
the boundaries.

The hallway pulses again, almost rhythmically. Lights turn red, then blue, then return to their usual cold white.

BENJAMIN
Whatever's here is losing control.
Or maybe it's gaining it.

Down the hall, another patient runs past them, face pale and twisted in terror, chased by shadows clinging to the walls.

BENJAMIN (CONT'D)
Agreed. We find Anna. We break out.

OTTO
And if she's not who we think?

BENJAMIN
Then we stop pretending any of this is what it seems.

As they walk forward, the hallway behind them slowly darkens-- like a void swallowing the past.

They don't look back.

FADE OUT.

INT. COMMON AREA - NEXT MORNING

The three sit in quiet tension. Outside the windows, the gray light flickers unnaturally, stuttering like a dying bulb.

The air feels heavier than usual. Something unsaid hangs between them.

Suddenly--

INTERCOM (DISTORTED)
Benjamin Price, report to Dr.
Anna's office immediately.

The voice is garbled, deep and echoing. A sharp hiss follows before it cuts out.

REGAN
That didn't even sound like her.

OTTO
She never uses the intercom. Ever.

BENJAMIN
Maybe she's scared. Or maybe she's
fucking with us.

REGAN

Either way... this is it.

OTTO

We'll be right outside the door.
If you feel anything's wrong,
knock twice. We'll force our way
in.

BENJAMIN

No matter what she says... don't
leave.

They exchange solemn nods. Benjamin rises and walks away
without looking back.

INT. DR. ANNA'S OFFICE - MOMENTS LATER

Benjamin enters. The door shuts on its own behind him. He
doesn't notice.

The room is dim, steeped in incense and silence. Candles
flicker on high shelves, casting fractured light across
framed diplomas and crystals.

Anna sits behind her desk, poised as always--yet something
is different. Her smile is too wide. Her stillness, too
perfect.

DR. ANNA

Hello, Benjamin.

BENJAMIN

Hello.

DR. ANNA

How are we feeling today?

BENJAMIN

Same as yesterday.

DR. ANNA

And how was your evening? Did you
rest?

Benjamin starts to answer but trails off--he's noticed
something.

In the corner of the room sits a young woman. She looks
about 17 or 18, dressed in slightly out-of-place
clothing--modern, like she walked out of a suburban bedroom
rather than a hospital.

Her fingers move slowly across the floor, tracing invisible
shapes.

DR. ANNA (CONT'D)
Benjamin, do you like puzzles?

BENJAMIN
Excuse me?

DR. ANNA
Puzzles. Little pieces coming
together. Making something bigger.
Making sense.

The girl lets out a soft giggle. Benjamin turns toward her,
but--

DR. ANNA (SHARPLY) (CONT'D)
Don't. Don't pay her any
attention. She's not supposed to
talk.

The girl looks up, directly at Benjamin, but her eyes seem
to shimmer--like light flickering on water.

GIRL
He's going to say it. Just watch.
He'll answer this time.

DR. ANNA (FURIOUS)
Stop it. He'll answer when he's
ready!

Anna's voice breaks--not like a doctor losing patience, but
like a teenager snapping at a sibling.

Benjamin flinches. Anna quickly recomposes, regaining her
tone.

DR. ANNA (GENTLY NOW) (CONT'D)
Tell me about the colors in your
dreams. Are they vivid?

BENJAMIN (AGITATED)
What is this? An intern?

GIRL (SMILING)
Ask him about the birds.

DR. ANNA
Enough! You're ruining it! This
isn't a game!

The room darkens slightly, and the candles flare, casting
long, warped shadows behind Anna.

Benjamin grips the armrest tightly. A high-pitched sound
creeps into the room--barely perceptible, like a
television left on in another room.

BENJAMIN (QUIETLY)
I think... I think I'd like to end

the session early today.

DR. ANNA
Of course. I'm sorry for the
distraction.

Benjamin rises.

He glances back toward the girl--

She's gone.

Only the empty chair remains, gently rocking.

He looks back at Anna, whose face remains still, expression
unchanged.

BENJAMIN
What are you?

Anna smiles faintly. A candle near her blinks out.

INT. HALLWAY OUTSIDE - CONTINUOUS

Regan and Otto wait in silence.

From inside the office:

A faint girl's laughter.

A loud knock.

Then nothing.

INT. COMMON ROOM - NIGHT

The room is dim, lit only by a flickering wall sconce. Shadows bend unnaturally along the walls. Benjamin enters slowly, the door creaking shut behind him. Regan and Otto rise from their chairs, tense.

He doesn't speak right away--just sinks into the chair like the air has been sucked from his lungs.

REGAN
What happened in there?

BENJAMIN
She wasn't alone. There was a
girl-- just sitting there, like
she belonged. She kept... smiling.
Giggling. Like the whole thing was
funny.

OTTO
What do you mean "funny"?

BENJAMIN
I don't know. But she kept saying
I was going to "answer." Like I
was supposed to... play along.

REGAN
Anna always knows too much. But
that... that's different.

BENJAMIN
She snapped. Not at me--at the
girl. Lost her composure
completely. It was like a mask
slipped off and something else was
underneath.

OTTO
And you just walked out?

BENJAMIN
I don't think I was supposed to.
(beat)
I think something broke in there.

The overhead light flickers, buzzing sharply--then bursts,
showering sparks. The room dims further.

A deep pulse vibrates through the floor--faint but
undeniable. Dust falls from the ceiling. Regan grabs the
edge of the table.

REGAN
It's not even pretending anymore.

A hairline crack splits across the far wall, crawling like
a vein. The light from the hallway turns blood-red for a
moment--then fades.

OTTO
I'm done waiting around for
answers that never come.

REGAN
We expose her. Trap her. Trick
her. Burn it down if we have to.

BENJAMIN
No more sessions. No more polite
questions. Anna's the one who
needs to start answering.

They all fall silent. The air thickens, tinged with the
scent of smoke, earth, and rot.

Far in the distance: a scream, sharp and childlike.
Malachai.

Then--total silence. They don't move. The room pulses once, slow and heavy, like a final heartbeat.

Malachai runs into the room and approaches Benjamin.

MALACHAI
You made trouble! YOU HAD NO
RIGHT!

JACE
Come on you little freak.

Jace grabs Malachai and carries him off.

MALACHAI
(screaming, thrashing)
Put me down, you bastard! You
don't touch me! You don't get to
touch me! I'll kill you, I swear--
(voice cracks)
I'll tear your eyes out! I'll--
(breath hitching)
I'll... I want my mom.
(sobbing)
I want my mom. Please. I just want
her. I didn't mean to stay. I
didn't mean it.
(quiet, broken)
She said she'd come back. Can I go
back to her now? Please?! I'll be
better this time. I promise. I
want to try again! Why didn't Dad
lock up the gun?? How was I
supposed to know??

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. DR. ANNA'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Otto sits stiffly in the chair across from Dr. Anna. The candlelight flickers more violently than usual. The crystals on the shelf vibrate ever so slightly. The room seems smaller than usual, tighter, warped at the edges.

DR. ANNA
Hello, Otto. How are we feeling
today?

OTTO
Spare me the routine.

DR. ANNA

(pause)

Very well. What would you like to discuss?

OTTO

My assignment. My punishment. Because that's what this is, isn't it?

DR. ANNA

Otto, you're here for your safety. For your peace.

OTTO

LIES.

He shoots up from the chair. The candles gutter. The shadows in the room twist unnaturally--as if recoiling.

OTTO (CONT'D)

I remember the trenches. The blood. The sound of artillery--Kaiser be damned, I survived worse than this. And now I'm trapped in your haunted dollhouse of lies!

DR. ANNA

Please calm down.

OTTO

You speak in riddles. Burn your little herbs. You have no idea what we've seen--what we've felt. I was a human being once! Now, what am I? A pawn? A toy?? What the fuck is this??

He grabs a candle and hurls it against the wall. It hits hard --but instead of shattering, the flame simply snuffs out, and the room tilts slightly, as if gravity hesitated.

DR. ANNA

Otto. That's enough.

OTTO

You think I don't know what's going on? That I'm just some shell- shocked relic? I see the cracks! The walls breathe. The air hums. You're not in charge here.

DR. ANNA
(standing abruptly)
This session is over.

OTTO
Convenient.

He glares at her, his chest rising and falling sharply. The lights flicker as he clenches his fists. Anna reaches for a small bronze bell, old and strange, etched with unfamiliar symbols.

She rings it once.

The sound is not pleasant--it's thin, metallic, and somehow wet. Like bone dragged across tile.

A moment passes.

The door behind Otto creaks open on its own, slow and deliberate. Cold air spills in.

DR. ANNA
Please leave, Otto. Goodbye.

OTTO
You first.

They lock eyes. Otto's stare is molten, unwavering.

Then, slowly, he turns and exits--his gaze never breaking until the very last second.

INT. COMMON ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Benjamin and Regan sit at a table, heads close in quiet debate. Otto storms in, jaw clenched, eyes wild.

REGAN
What happened? Are you okay?

OTTO
She tried to shut me down. But I saw it. I felt it.

BENJAMIN
What do you mean?

OTTO
She's not in charge anymore--if she ever was. There's something else behind all this.

OTTO (CONT'D)

I said things she didn't want to hear. Asked questions she couldn't answer.

REGAN

Did she react?

OTTO

Like I hit a nerve. She rang some kind of bell--sounded like bones grinding together. Then the door opened on its own.

BENJAMIN

So, she is hiding something.

OTTO

More than that. She's afraid.

REGAN

Good. Let her be. Now it's her turn to feel powerless.

They exchange a grim look.

Something in the walls cracks quietly, like a seam splitting.

OTTO

At the very least, I rattled her cage.

Benjamin and Regan nod in agreement. The shadows behind them seem to lean forward, listening.

FADE OUT.

INT. COMMON ROOM - LATER THAT NIGHT

The lighting is dimmer than usual. The corners of the room seem to breathe, expanding and contracting almost imperceptibly. The walls hum, like a tuning fork struck in some distant part of the building.

Regan and Benjamin sit across from Otto, who is visibly unraveling. His leg bounces, his hands tremble, his eyes dart as if trying to remember where he is.

REGAN

Otto, what is it? You're scaring me.

OTTO
I don't think I'm supposed to be
here anymore.

BENJAMIN
What are you talking about?

OTTO
Something happened when I yelled
at her. Something... cracked. I
felt it inside me, like the floor
gave out.
(beat)
And now I feel like I have to
leave.

He clutches his chest--not in pain, but like he's holding
himself together.

The room hums louder, as though reacting to his words.

REGAN
And go where? How??

Before he can answer, the overhead light sputters, dims to
a dull orange, then steadies. The air grows heavy--like
thick velvet pressing down on them.

A low tone begins. Deep. Resonant. Inhuman.

Then--

From the far doorway, two tall, shadowed figures appear.

Dressed in antiquated white coats, their features are
indistinct, blurred at the edges like bad reception. Their
shoes make no sound as they move forward.

BENJAMIN
Otto...

OTTO
No. No, not yet-- (then suddenly a
flicker of clarity) Wait--
(realization dawning)
I need to tell you--

The figures reach him, flanking him without urgency. Each
takes an arm, and Otto immediately fights, jerking away.

OTTO (CONT'D)
Listen to me! This place-- It's
not--
(he chokes)
Oh God, how did we not see it?

REGAN

Otto!

OTTO

I'm not ready! Please! I'm not--

The figures begin to drag him.

His feet scrape across the floor. His voice rises in desperation, but there's a stillness in the room that swallows sound.

OTTO (CONT'D)

Don't trust her! Don't -- she's
just a....

SLAM.

The door shuts behind him, unnaturally loud. Final.

A faint echo of Otto's scream lingers for just a breath... then is gone.

Silence.

Benjamin and Regan don't move. They stare at the door, eyes glassy, bodies tense. The light above them buzzes softly, then goes out, leaving only the flicker of red from the hallway.

The room pulses once, like a final exhale.

BENJAMIN (QUIETLY)

He was right.

REGAN

(Through tears)

Oh god....

They sit in the dark.

No one breathes.

The camera holds too long.

Then--

In the corner, something moves, but when they turn--there's nothing there.

The door slams shut behind them.

Silence.

Benjamin and Regan stare at the door, unmoving, stunned. The room pulses once like a dying breath.

FADE OUT.

INT. STAIRWELL LANDING - NIGHT

A low whine hums through the air. Red emergency lights flash dimly, distorting shadows along the cracked walls. Dust hangs like smoke.

Regan and Benjamin sit huddled on the landing between floors. Benjamin clutches a broken clipboard, Regan trembles--but holds it in.

They've been running. Or hiding. Or both.

Footsteps echo from above.

REGAN
(sharp whisper)
Someone's coming.

BENJAMIN
Stay behind me.

They tense--until a familiar figure descends the stairs, limping slightly.

JACE.

REGAN

Jace!

JACE
Found you.

He doesn't smile. His face is streaked with dirt and sweat, and his knuckles are scraped.

BENJAMIN
Where have you been?

JACE
Watching.

He sits across from them, leaning against the wall like he's been carrying bricks on his back. He stares at the space between them-- unblinking.

JACE (CONT'D)
They're all gone.

REGAN
Who's gone?

JACE
All of them. Carmilla. Lucy. That quiet girl with the drawings. They're not here anymore.

BENJAMIN
ALL of them?? Do you know where they've gone???

JACE
I saw the orderlies. They came, one by one. They don't all scream like Otto. Some just... give up.

REGAN
How did they take Lucy? She never made a sound.

JACE
Didn't have to. She knew. She walked with them.

BENJAMIN
Jesus...

JACE
I thought if I stayed in the vents, or in that hallway that loops, they wouldn't see me. But I saw them. I saw all of them.

REGAN
Why are you still here?

JACE
Don't know. Maybe I'm not interesting enough. Maybe I'm not healed yet.

He runs his hand across the concrete floor, smearing old ash into the lines between the tiles.

JACE (CONT'D)
This place-- It doesn't want to be fixed. You have to adapt to it, learn it. That's the game.

BENJAMIN
That's what the girl said... back in Anna's office. Like we were pieces of something.

JACE
Pieces that get rearranged. Until
they fit. Or snap.

REGAN
(low)
I think I'm going to be next.

They both look at her. Benjamin tenses, but says nothing.

REGAN (CONT'D)
I feel it in my stomach. Like it's
already pulling on me. And I'm not
scared of dying. I'm scared of not
existing.

JACE
You'll still be something. Just
not... here.

BENJAMIN
No. We're not losing anyone else.

REGAN
You don't get to decide that,
Benjamin.

BENJAMIN
Then what the hell can I decide?

JACE
It's not about deciding. It's
about resisting. Stay
uncomfortable. Stay angry. That's
the only thing they can't control.

He looks at the flickering stairwell light above. It's
turning in slow circles now, like a halo twisted sideways.

JACE (CONT'D)
You can feel it too, right?

They all go still. In the distance, a loud CRACK splits the
silence.

A scream? Or metal? It's impossible to tell anymore.

REGAN
If they take me... I don't want to
go the way Otto did.

BENJAMIN
You won't.

REGAN
I mean it. If you see me walking
away with them--stop me.

BENJAMIN
I will.

JACE
I'll hurt them if I have to.

REGAN
They're not afraid of pain.

BENJAMIN
Maybe they'll be afraid of us.

They fall silent again. The light bulb finally bursts,
showering glass down the stairwell like quiet rain.

The three sit in the darkness, back to back, as the sound
of distant whispers begins to fill the space below them.

FADE OUT.

INT. COMMON ROOM - EARLY MORNING

The air is thick. Heavy. Like it's resisting being
breathed. Every corner of the room seems darker than it
should be.

The lights buzz, pulsing like a weak heartbeat. Shadows
stretch unnaturally across the cracked linoleum.

Benjamin and Regan sit on the floor near the wall, knees
drawn up, backs barely touching. The silence between them
is loaded, brimming with things unsaid.

REGAN
(low)
My head... It's like pressure.

REGAN (CONT'D)
Building. Like it's going to split
open. You think it's what Otto
felt?

BENJAMIN
No. Don't say that.

REGAN
Maybe it is the same. Maybe worse.
Maybe I'm dying.

She grips the sides of her head and shakes slightly, like her mind is vibrating apart. Her voice falters, too exhausted to cry.

Suddenly--a low hum fills the room.

Familiar. Dreadful.

The kind of sound you feel before you hear.

Benjamin stiffens. Regan's breath catches in her throat.

From the doorway, two tall, shadowed figures appear. The Orderlies.

Their forms are flickering, as if poorly rendered. Their features remain faceless, stretched thin like wax too close to heat.

BENJAMIN

No.

REGAN

Please. Help me.

He grabs her hand. She grips it with desperate force, her fingers cold.

REGAN (CONT'D)

I don't want to go. Not like this.
I don't even know where I'm going.
Where do they take you?

BENJAMIN

You're not. I won't let them take you.

The first figure steps forward, gliding rather than walking. It reaches out, placing a hand on Regan's shoulder.

She gasps sharply, a scream stuck in her throat.

REGAN

(shaky)
I can't breathe. Oh
God--Benjamin--

Benjamin and orderly fight. He loses after being grabbed and thrown down hard. He crawls over to Regan, she sits on the floor crying.

He leans forward quickly and grabs her hands in his, kissing her fingers.

BENJAMIN
I'm so sorry. For everything. I am
so sorry I can't stop this.

Her lip trembles. She's shaking hard now.

REGAN
I'm scared.

The second figure moves in. Places a hand on her arm.

She begins to thrash, her legs kicking as if caught in undertow, nails digging into the floor, scratching gouges into the tile.

BENJAMIN
Stop! She's not ready!

He lunges, grabs at the figure's wrist. It throws him back like paper, and he crashes into a chair, ribs smacking hard.

REGAN
Benjamin! Please! Don't let
them--!

Her scream turns to a sob as she's lifted from the floor, feet dragging, leaving smudged red from her scraped fingers.

BENJAMIN
REGAN!

The lights flicker violently. The walls moan with pressure.

REGAN
(realization crosses her face, she
smile) Oh my god..... Benjamin.
It's going to be OK! Please don't
forget me... I will see you soon.

She reaches back--her fingers so close, but out of reach.

And then she's gone.

The door slams shut behind them with a THUNDEROUS boom.

INT. COMMON ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Benjamin stands still for a full moment.

He stares at the door.

And then drops.

He collapses to his knees, hands hanging limp, shaking.
Tears begin to fall silently, but his face is blank.

BENJAMIN
(whispers)
You said you'd stay.

His breath begins to quicken, turn sharp.

Then the first sound leaves his throat: a howl.

A deep, raw, guttural scream that rips up from his chest
and tears the silence in half.

He punches the floor once. Twice. A third time.

Then he just sobs.

For a long, long time.

INT. HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER

The building rattles, its bones unsettled.

Smoke creeps from beneath the common room door, rising like
fog across Benjamin's shoes as he stumbles down the hall.

His hands tremble. His eyes are wild. Haunted.

INT. DR. ANNA'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

The door swings open before he touches it.

Dr. Anna stands in the center of the room, lit from behind
by flickering candlelight and rolling smoke.

DR. ANNA
Hello, Benjamin. Welcome.

He steps forward, still trembling, rage boiling over
sorrow.

BENJAMIN
You knew. You KNEW they were going
to take Regan.

DR. ANNA
Regan is gone?? No... I never
know. But it's not permanent here.
Not for anyone. I would help you
if I could. If I knew how.

BENJAMIN

Don't lie to me. You let them take Otto. You let them take Regan. You sit here on your crystal throne like some gatekeeper--

DR. ANNA

(shaken)

I never meant for this. My mother warned me. She said... She said I should never play with things I didn't understand.

BENJAMIN

Play with what?

DR. ANNA

(whispers)

The board.

BENJAMIN

WHAT? We buried that board!

DR. ANNA

You weren't supposed to know. But yes. I opened something. I thought I could talk to them. Help them. Help you. But now the door's too wide. Something else came through.

The smoke thickens. Benjamin stumbles, falls to his knees, clutching his head.

The scent of sage is overwhelming, but rotten underneath.

BENJAMIN

What's happening?

DR. ANNA

They must be coming. I'm so sorry. You were my favorite.

She backs away, vanishing into the swirling smoke.

Two hands reach from behind, grab Benjamin by the arms.

He screams--a cry of raw fear, sorrow, and rage--as he's dragged backward through the fog, through the office, through the walls--

EXT. LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

A teenage girl stands in front of a fireplace.

The room is quiet, save for the ticking of a clock and the flicker of firelight. In her hands: a Ouija board that closely resembles colors and patterns of hospital.

She stares at it, eyes wide. Lips trembling.

Then, slowly -- She throws it into the flames.

As the flames surround it -- The faint sound of Benjamin's scream echoes.

Then silence.

FADE TO BLACK.

EXT. MEADOW - ETERNAL SUNSET

Soft golden light blankets the field. Wildflowers sway gently. The air is warm and calm, filled with birdsong and the hum of distant wind chimes.

BENJAMIN lies in tall grass, eyes blinking open to the sky. His brow, once furrowed with fear, is smooth now. He exhales.

A voice calls from nearby.

REGAN (O.S.)
Benjamin.

He sits up.

She's standing a few feet away in the field, barefoot in the flowers, hair lit like a halo in the sunset. She smiles -- real and full.

His eyes fill with tears.

He walks to her. She meets him halfway, and they embrace like they never thought they'd see each other again.

In the distance, Otto laughs, sitting with Amber and Carmilla beneath a tree, playing cards on a picnic blanket.

No one speaks of pain. Or loss. Or the hospital.

Only peace.

BENJAMIN
Is this... real?

REGAN
It's real enough.

She takes his hand.

They turn toward the others. Together.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. DARK ROOM - UNKNOWN TIME

A soft scratching echoes in the darkness.

A dim light reveals JACE, crouched near a crumbling wall, dragging a jagged object across the surface.

Dozens of tally marks scar the space around him.

One more.

He leans back. Eyes hollow.

A sound behind him.

A door creaks open.

He doesn't turn.

JACE
(quietly)
Hello?

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

A flickering candle casts shadows across a teenage girl's face as she kneels on the floor of her suburban bedroom.

She pulls a half-burned Ouija board from a thrift shop bag. Curious, she places it gently on the carpet.

She hesitates, then touches a crystal glass lying where a planchette should be, but is missing.

TEEN GIRL
What's your name?

The marker begins to move.
J... A... C... E.

TEEN GIRL (CONT'D)

Hi, Jace.

The candle flickers violently.

Somewhere behind her, a shadow stirs.

She doesn't notice.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END